

Self-behaviour-development — compiled path

Compiled from `/Users/darkonikolic/Documents/learning/paths/Self-behaviour-development`. Canonical sources stay in place.

Phase — 01-operational-stance

Directory: `01-operational-stance/`

Source: `01-operational-stance/01-program-orientation-and-area-map.md`

How this learning path works

What this is

This path teaches practical behavioural skills for high-pressure situations — conversations, conflicts, difficult relationships, institutional settings. The skills cover everything from staying calm in the moment to understanding your own thinking patterns to managing your physical state under stress.

The files are short on purpose. The value comes from practising the moves, not from reading more pages.

How to use it

You do not need to go in order. Use the self-check below to find where you are leaking most right now — then open that folder.

Self-check — read each line and notice which feels weakest:

- I take a breath before responding when something hits me
- I say one thing, stop, and wait — instead of stacking arguments
- I stay calm in my body before my mind tries to win an argument
- I only engage with one tactic at a time, not multiple at once
- I keep my emotional state contained when it matters

Whichever row feels consistently weak — that is where you start.

Three-question check (takes 60 seconds):

1. Who is the most high-stakes person or situation in my life right now? _____
2. Which row above disappears most often under pressure? _____
3. Which folder number should I open next (see map below)? _____

Folder map

#	Folder	What it covers
01	01-operational-stance/	The core filter (does this matter?), in-the-moment decision steps, short daily phrases to stay grounded
02	02-regulation-and-recovery/	Calming your body before speaking, honest delay phrases, sleep, fatigue, movement, food, decision overload
03	03-observer-loop/	Noticing what your body, impulses, and story are doing separately — and reviewing conversations without shame
04	04-cognitive-distortion-literacy/	Five thinking errors that inflate conflict, three biases that distort judgment, how to sit with uncertainty
05	05-communication-under-pressure/	Pacing your responses, structuring what you say, staying present under pressure
06	06-situation-literacy/	Reading what is actually happening in a situation versus what you are being told is happening
07	07-audiences-channels-boundaries/	Who to say what to — and how to stop feeding situations that drain you
08	08-behaviour-as-signal/	How your behaviour communicates stability or instability, regardless of your words
09	09-daily-mechanics/	A short pre-contact habit before difficult conversations or messages
10	10-drills-and-exercise-archive/	Practice scenarios and integration exercises
11	11-reflection-evening-loop/	Three questions to end the day without spiralling
12	12-active-life-design/	Building a real life beyond just managing conflict
13	13-professional-work-load/	Workplace stress and how it compounds everything else
14	14-appendix-custody-expert-proceedings/	Preparation for formal proceedings and evaluations

One thing to remember

Reading these files changes nothing. Practising the moves changes behaviour.

Files in this folder

- [Does this actually matter? The three-question filter](#)
- [In-the-moment decision steps](#)
- [Short phrases to stay grounded](#)

Source: 01-operational-stance/02-energy-routing-triad-important-risky-goal.md

Does this actually matter? The three-question filter

What this is

Before you react to something — a message, a comment, a dig — run it through three quick questions. This takes under five seconds and stops you from spending real energy on things that do not deserve it.

The three questions are: 1. **Does this matter to my actual responsibilities?** 2. **Is there real risk here — something with consequences?** 3. **Is there a real goal I can actually work toward?**

If the answer to all three is no — stay quiet or respond minimally. Not every provocation needs a response. Not every injustice needs your energy right now.

When to use this

- You receive a message and feel the pull to respond immediately
- Someone says something designed to get a reaction from you

- You notice yourself about to enter an argument that has no real endpoint
- You are unsure whether to engage or let something go

How to do it

The filter (under 5 seconds):

Ask the three questions mentally. Use simple yes/no answers: - Important = yes / no - Risk = yes / no - Real goal = yes / no / none

If importance and goal both come back no — the answer is minimal response or silence.

If there is risk but no workable goal (you cannot resolve this through direct conversation) — shift to a factual, low-temperature approach, or handle it through the appropriate channel (written record, professional escalation) rather than a live argument.

Weekly practice:

Once a week, identify one place where you are regularly giving energy that returns nothing — a person, a group chat, a feed. Write down one clear limit for it. Note once if you slipped, without judgment.

Example

Someone sends a message taking a dig at a past decision you made. You feel the urge to defend yourself.

Filter check: - Does this matter to my responsibilities? No. - Is there real risk? No. - Is there a real goal? No — this person is not going to change their view and nothing material depends on this exchange.

Response: minimal or none.

Connects to

- [How this path works — folder map](#)
- [In-the-moment decision steps](#)
- [Conflict decision sequence](#)

Source: `01-operational-stance/03-fast-playbook.md`

In-the-moment decision steps

What this is

A simple sequence for the moment something happens — a message arrives, someone confronts you, a difficult situation starts. The sequence gives you a decision path so you are not improvising while already activated.

The whole thing runs in seconds. One breath → read the situation → choose a response mode → say one sentence → stop.

When to use this

- Something lands and you feel the urge to respond immediately
- A conversation starts going somewhere difficult
- You are in a room or on a call and something is escalating
- You need to say something but are not sure how much or what

How to do it

Step 1 — One breath before anything else. Not a pause for effect. An actual breath. This is the only mandatory thing.

Step 2 — Classify the situation in one word: - **Aggressive** — hostile, pushing, wanting a fight - **Manipulative** — playing games, testing you, leading you somewhere - **Institutional** — formal context, record-bearing, professional setting - **Normal** — a genuine, workable exchange

Step 3 — Choose your response mode: - **Engage** — normal dialogue, this is fine, participate fully - **Minimal** — say one neutral thing and nothing more - **Distance** — pull back from the conversation without disappearing - **Exit** — leave the exchange entirely (physically or by ending the message thread)

Step 4 — Say one sentence. Stop. Not two sentences. Not a follow-up clarification. One sentence, then wait. Let the other person respond before you add anything.

Second sentences are where regret usually lives. The impulse to keep going, to explain, to cover yourself — that impulse makes things worse more often than it helps.

Step 5 — Intensity check (0–4): If you need a quick read on how much to do: - **0** — ignore, give no response, starve it - **1** — one neutral sentence - **2** — state a clear limit - **3** — name that the conversation is ending - **4** — disconnect, leave, escalate formally

Example

You receive a message that feels aggressive and accusatory. Your impulse is to defend yourself at length.

Breath. Classify: aggressive. Response mode: minimal. Write one sentence that is factual and does not escalate. Send it. Stop. Do not follow up for at least 20 minutes.

Connects to

- [The three-question filter](#)
- [Calming your body before speaking](#)

Source: 01-operational-stance/04-three-layer-operational-mantra.md

Short phrases to stay grounded

What this is

A set of short memorised phrases you say to yourself — not to anyone else — that help you stay oriented when things get hard. They work faster than trying to reason your way through a difficult moment, because they bypass the mental argument and land directly in your body.

There are three layers, each for a different type of day:

- **Daily phrases** — short, used every morning or whenever you need a reset
- **Weekly phrases** — slightly wider, used a few times a week to connect your actions to what matters
- **Deep phrases** — for genuinely hard days, not for ordinary frustration

The layers are not a hierarchy. You do not graduate to the deep ones. You match the phrase to the day.

When to use this

- First thing in the morning before anything begins
- Before a difficult conversation or meeting
- When you feel yourself drifting — flat, reactive, or checked out
- On a genuinely hard day when you feel lost or numb

How to do it

Write your own phrases. The ones below are prompts to help you build yours. They should feel like things you actually believe, not borrowed language that sounds right but lands hollow.

Daily layer (30 seconds, every morning): Take a slow breath in and a longer breath out. Say your short phrases quietly — between breaths, not over them. Do not journal immediately after. Just let it sit.

Example prompt: What do I actually care about today? What is one true thing about my situation?

Weekly layer (a few minutes, a few times a week): Say your wider phrases slowly, out loud. Then name one specific behaviour you are going to lead with that day — something concrete. (“I will not draft that message before I have slept on it.” / “I will move my body before I open anything difficult.”)

At the end of the day, ask yourself one yes/no question: did I do that one thing? No essay required.

Deep layer (for genuinely hard days): When you feel numb, lost, or like nothing is moving — say your deep phrases once, quietly. Then do one small physical thing in the next ten minutes. Eat something. Walk one block. Open one specific file you have been avoiding. The phrase alone does nothing. The phrase plus one small action breaks the inertia.

One important limit

These phrases are for keeping yourself grounded, not for getting yourself worked up for a confrontation. If you find yourself using them to prepare for an argument, that is a signal to step back, not forward.

Connects to

- [The three-question filter](#)
 - [In-the-moment decision steps](#)
 - [Calming your body before speaking](#)
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Phase — 02-regulation-and-recovery

Directory: `02-regulation-and-recovery/`

Source: `02-regulation-and-recovery/01-grounding-micro-label-emotion.md`

Calm your body before you speak

What this is

When you are stressed, angry, or anxious, your body reacts before your mind catches up. If you speak or type from that activated state, what comes out is driven by the stress — not by clear thinking.

This file gives you two small habits:

1. **A physical reset before speaking** — feel your feet, relax your jaw, breathe out slowly, then speak or type.
2. **Name the emotion to yourself** — when you feel irritated or upset, say one word internally to name it before deciding whether to respond.

Neither of these is visible to anyone else. Both take under ten seconds.

When to use this

- Before responding to any message that activated you
- Before speaking in a difficult conversation
- When you notice your jaw is tight, your chest is tense, or you are holding your breath
- When irritation spikes and you feel the urge to say something immediately

How to do it

Physical reset (before speaking or typing):

1. Feel your feet on the floor — notice the contact, even briefly
2. Check your jaw — if it is tight, let it go slightly
3. Breathe out slowly, longer than the breath in
4. Now speak or type

That is the whole thing. It takes about five seconds. The point is not relaxation — it is that these three physical actions interrupt the automatic chain from stress to reaction.

Naming the emotion (when irritated alone or before a reply):

Say one word to yourself internally. Just one: “anger”, “fear”, “pressure”, “hurt”. Not a sentence. Not an explanation. Not a story about why.

After naming it, ask: do I respond now, or do I wait and come back to this?

This is not about suppressing the emotion. It is about creating a half-second gap between the feeling and the action.

Example

You read a message that feels unfair and accusatory. Your first impulse is to defend yourself immediately.

Instead: feet on the floor, jaw check, slow breath out. Then say to yourself: “anger”. Now decide — respond now or in 20 minutes? Most of the time, the answer is 20 minutes.

Connects to

- [Recognising when you are off and how to reset](#)
 - [In-the-moment decision steps](#)
 - [Sleep and fatigue signals](#)
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Recognising when you are off — and how to reset

What this is

Sometimes you are not just stressed — you are outside your functional state entirely. Looping thoughts, body locked up, pulled toward an argument you cannot stop thinking about, unable to think in a straight line. This is different from ordinary stress.

This file helps you recognise the signs that you are in that state, gives you a reset sequence that takes under 30 seconds, and teaches you how to buy honest time when you need it — without lying about why.

When to use this

- Your thoughts are cycling through the same conflict over and over
- Your voice or neck feels locked up
- You feel a magnetic pull toward the argument — you keep coming back to it
- You cannot think clearly about anything else
- You are about to respond to something and you know you should not yet

How to do it

Step 1 — Know your own signs.

Write down six things that happen to you specifically when you are in this state. Not generic signs — yours. Examples: jaw clenches, words come out sharper, you start skim-reading, you open the same message five times. Post this list somewhere you will actually see it.

Step 2 — The 30-second reset.

When you recognise you are off: 1. Name what is happening internally — one word or a short tag (“conflict loop”, “too activated right now”) 2. Drop your shoulders and breathe out 3. Do one small action: a single sentence of calm response, staying silent, or saying an honest delay phrase

Do not try to resolve the conflict, win the argument, or explain yourself while in this state. The only goal is to not make it worse.

Step 3 — Use honest delay phrases.

When you need more time before responding, say something that is actually true. Do not invent a deadline or make up a reason.

Examples of honest delay phrases: - “I need to check something before I respond to this.” - “I’ll come back to this after I look at the details.” - “I want to give this a proper answer — let me get back to you tomorrow.”

The test: is the timeline you are giving real? If you are promising to respond by Tuesday but have no intention of doing so by Tuesday, that undermines trust. If the timeline is honest, use the phrase freely.

Anchoring (optional, only if you do the groundwork):

Some people use a physical anchor — a small repeated action (touching a knuckle, a specific phrase) that they pair with a calm state over many nights. This only works if you have actually practised pairing it with a genuinely calm moment, at least five or six times. Without that pairing, it is just a gesture.

Example

You get a message at 10pm that sets off a conflict loop. You know you are going to keep re-reading it. You feel the pull to respond right now.

Instead: shoulders down, breathe out. Say to yourself: “too activated right now”. Send nothing. Write in a notepad what you want to say — do not send it. Come back to it in the morning. That is the reset.

Connects to

- [Calm your body before you speak](#)
 - [Observer — noticing body, impulse, and story separately](#)
 - [Sleep and fatigue signals](#)
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Sleep and fatigue — how they affect your behaviour

What this is

Poor sleep does not just make you tired. It narrows your empathy, makes threats feel bigger than they are, sharpens your tone, and makes you more likely to misread situations. This happens before you consciously notice it.

This file is not about sleep hygiene ideology. It is about treating sleep and fatigue as inputs that directly affect how you behave — the same way fuel affects an engine. Know your signals. Set a few non-negotiable habits. Track the trend.

When to use this

- You are in a difficult or high-stakes period and need your behaviour to hold up
- You notice your tone getting sharper or your thinking getting more catastrophic
- You keep saying “I blew it again” at the end of difficult days
- A heavy week is coming and you want to prepare

How to do it

Step 1 — Know your personal fatigue signals.

Write down seven things that happen to you specifically when you are sleep-depleted or running on empty. Generic examples to help you find yours: you snap at small things, you skim-read important messages, you spiral into worst-case thinking, you reach for sugar or caffeine compulsively, you feel vaguely angry at nothing specific.

Post this list somewhere visible. The goal is to catch it early — before the behaviour is already happening.

Step 2 — Set three sleep habits you will actually keep.

Not an ideal sleep protocol. Three realistic things you will do consistently given your actual life. Examples: a consistent wake time, no phone for 30 minutes before bed, no caffeine after 2pm. Choose what you will keep, not what sounds best.

Step 3 — Track the trend, not the number.

Once a week, write one line in your calendar or notes: is your sleep trending up, flat, or down? That is all. No detailed logging, no self-judgment. Just the direction.

Step 4 — Log honestly when it correlates with conflict.

When you have a bad interaction or a difficult day, note alongside it: how many hours did you sleep? Was the previous week high-stress? This builds an honest picture over time — a witness table, not a verdict on your character.

Step 5 — Plan recovery before a hard week.

When you know something demanding is coming, put a recovery block on your calendar in advance. It does not need to be large. Even 45 minutes of genuine rest counts. The point is to do it intentionally rather than collapsing at the end.

Connects to

- [Calm your body before you speak](#)
 - [Movement and nutrition under stress](#)
-

Movement and food — simple basics that affect how you handle stress

What this is

When you are under sustained stress, how you move, eat, and hydrate directly affects the quality of your thinking and your ability to stay even-tempered. This is not ideology or biohacking. It is a simple acknowledgment that your brain runs on a body, and a depleted body makes everything harder.

This file sets a realistic floor — the minimum habits that are actually worth keeping — rather than an ambitious programme that falls apart in a difficult week.

When to use this

- You are in a high-pressure period and notice your responses getting worse
- You are making decisions on an empty stomach or after hours without moving
- You want to build a simple baseline that holds up even in hard weeks

How to do it

Step 1 — Set an honest movement floor.

Not a fitness goal. A floor — the minimum you will actually do on a bad day. Examples: walk one block, take the stairs, do five minutes of stretching before bed. Be honest about what you will actually keep. Write it down. Track it with a simple hash mark (did it / didn't do it).

Truth is more useful than ambition here.

Step 2 — Set hydration and meal timing checkpoints.

If you have a history of escalating arguments when you have not eaten — take that seriously. Set a few fixed points in the day where you drink water and eat something. They do not need to be elaborate. They need to happen.

Step 3 — Prepare three default meals.

When you are depleted, decision-making about food collapses. Have three simple meals you can make or grab without thinking — something frozen, something easy to cook, something you can buy nearby. Remove the decision when your capacity is lowest.

Step 4 — Be honest about alcohol under stress.

This file does not lecture. But if alcohol is a regular response to stress, note honestly what it costs behaviourally — not in general terms, but for you specifically. One line, no sermon.

Connects to

- [Sleep and fatigue signals](#)
- [Decision fatigue and energy budgeting](#)

Decision fatigue — managing overload before it manages you

What this is

Every decision you make costs something. When you have too many open decisions, too many unresolved situations, and no recovery time, the quality of your thinking drops — often before you notice it is happening. Your words get sharper, your patience shrinks, your judgment gets worse.

This file gives you a simple system for managing where your attention goes, capping decisions before the well runs dry, and protecting at least one recovery block per week.

When to use this

- You feel like everything is urgent and nothing is getting done
- Your patience and judgment are noticeably worse than usual
- You are making impulsive decisions or saying things you regret
- You have a stretch of heavy days coming and want to protect yourself

How to do it

Step 1 — Keep a simple attention log on weekdays.

Sort your open items into three columns: - Must decide today - Can wait (name a real date) - Belongs to someone else or to a formal process

Anything in the third column — remove it from your mental load today. It is not yours to carry right now.

Step 2 — Cap heavy decisions per day.

Decide on a realistic number of genuinely difficult decisions you can make well in one day. When you hit that number, stop. Queue anything extra to tomorrow. This is not laziness — it is accuracy about how human attention works.

Step 3 — Protect one recovery block per week.

Put it on the calendar like a medical appointment. It does not have to be long. It does not have to be exciting. Even quiet time spent on logistics you have been avoiding counts. The point is that it is protected and it happens.

Step 4 — Automate the small decisions.

Every micro-decision you make on autopilot is one you do not have to pay for. Set defaults for routine things: what you eat in the morning, what you wear on workdays, what your evening routine is. These sound trivial. Over a week, they add up.

Step 5 — When you overload, review these four things.

After a week where everything went sideways, write three honest bullet points covering: how was your sleep, did you move and eat, what decisions stayed open and drained you, and what could go on someone else's plate. No essay. Just the facts.

Connects to

- [Movement and food basics](#)
 - [Recognising when you are off and resetting](#)
 - [In-the-moment decision steps](#)
 - [The three-question filter](#)
-

Phase — 03-observer-loop

Directory: `03-observer-loop/`

Source: `03-observer-loop/01-meta-observer-three-levels.md`

Noticing your body, your impulse, and the story — separately

What this is

In a difficult moment, three things happen at once: your body reacts (tension, heat, held breath), you feel an impulse (to flee, to attack, to go silent), and your mind starts telling a story about what this means. Usually all three collapse into one automatic reaction.

This skill is about learning to notice the three channels separately, rather than fusing into the first story that arrives. You do not need to act on any of them immediately. You just need to see them as distinct.

This matters because the story your mind offers first — especially under stress — is often wrong. Separating the channels gives you a moment to choose, rather than react.

When to use this

- During a difficult conversation, to stay steady instead of being swept along
- After a difficult exchange, to understand what actually happened
- When you feel a strong automatic reaction and want to understand where it is coming from
- As a daily practice to build the habit of observation

How to do it

During a difficult moment:

As something is happening, notice which channel is loudest. Just name it internally — body, impulse, or story. You do not need to do anything else. Just the naming creates a small gap.

Practice (15 prompts):

Work through a list of 15 recent situations or imagined scenarios — anything that would normally activate you. For each one, identify which channel came first: - **Body** — physical sensation (tightness, heat, held breath) - **Impulse** — what you wanted to do (leave, fight, go silent, scroll away) - **Story** — what your mind said it meant (“they always do this”, “this proves they hate me”)

Answer quickly. No need to defend or analyse your answer.

Two-minute sit:

Sit quietly for two minutes. Every time you notice a craving or impulse (check the phone, replay a scenario, imagine a response), say “impulse” internally, then take one breath. You are not trying to eliminate impulses. You are practising catching them before they become actions.

After a difficult conversation:

Write down three tokens — three words that describe what happened internally: - Were you in observer mode (noticing without reacting)? - What was the impulse? - Where did you slip and on what?

The right order

Observe what is happening in your body and mind first. Then calm your body if needed. Then check whether your interpretation is accurate. Then choose what to say. Never reverse this order when you are activated.

Connects to

- [After a difficult conversation — review without shame](#)
- [Calming your body before speaking](#)

- [In-the-moment decision steps](#)
- [Five thinking errors that amplify conflict](#)

Source: 03-observer-loop/02-after-talk-reset-and-review.md

After a difficult conversation — review without shame

What this is

After a hard conversation or a difficult exchange, the mind tends to run a prosecutorial replay: everything that went wrong, everything you said badly, evidence that you ruined it. This loop is not useful. It does not produce insight — it produces shame and fatigue.

This file replaces that loop with a three-line write-up that takes under two minutes and actually helps.

When to use this

- After any conversation that felt difficult, tense, or like it went sideways
- When you notice yourself replaying an exchange repeatedly
- At the end of a hard day, before bed, to close things down instead of leaving them open
- Any time the “I ruined everything” story starts running

How to do it

As soon as possible after a difficult exchange, write three lines. No more.

Line	What to write
What happened	One neutral sentence describing the event. No interpretation. Just what occurred: “I received a message accusing me of X. I replied by Y.”
How I responded	Two or three descriptive words only — no judgment. Not “I was terrible”. Just: “short”, “loud”, “defensive”, “cold”.
One thing I would do differently	Name one specific behaviour for next time. Not a character resolution (“I will be calmer”). A specific action: “I would wait 20 minutes before responding.”

That is it. No fourth line. No retrospective analysis. The “everything is ruined” version of events is not allowed in this table.

After writing:

Take one slow breath out. Drop your shoulders. Say to yourself: “that was one exchange, not a verdict”. Then close the notebook or the document.

Evening check:

If shame starts up at bedtime, pause it with the table. Dictate or handwrite the three lines if typing feels like too much. The structure matters — it forces specificity and stops the spiral.

Example

Difficult conversation: a tense call that ended badly.

- What happened: “The call became an argument about the schedule. I raised my voice near the end and it finished abruptly.”
- How I responded: “Rushed, loud, cut off.”
- One thing differently: “I would have said ‘let me call you back tomorrow’ instead of continuing when I was already too activated.”

Done. That is the whole review.

Connects to

- [Noticing your body, impulse, and story separately](#)
- [Three evening review questions](#)

Observer daily log — channel inventory, not self-prosecution

After any contact that activated your system — difficult conversation, written exchange, or internal pressure spike — fill this within 30 minutes. Sooner than that: too hot. Later than 30 min: details blur.

The three channels

You observe these simultaneously. The goal is to name them — not fuse into the story.

Channel	What it tracks	Example signal
Body	Physical sensations, tension, breath changes	Chest tightening, jaw clenching, faster breathing, stillness
Impulse	Urge to act before thinking	Want to reply now, want to leave, want to prove, want to snipe
Story	The narrative your mind generates	"They're trying to corner me", "I'm failing", "This means..."

Post-contact entry (fill within 30 min)

Date / time: _____

Contact type: ☐ In-person ☐ Written ☐ Phone ☐ Internal pressure (no contact)

Context (1 line): _____

BODY — what did I notice?

IMPULSE — what did I want to do in the moment?

STORY — what narrative ran first?

Did I act from body/impulse, or did I observe first?

☐ Observed first — paused, then responded

☐ Acted from impulse — response came before observation

☐ Mixed — partly observed, partly reactive

What did I actually do?

One token label:

☐ Observer-stable — noticed without fusing

☐ Impulse — acted from urgency

☐ Slipped on: _____ (name the specific distortion or pattern)

Worked example

Date / time: 2026-03-14 18:45
Contact type: [x] Written — email from opposing party
Context: Message questioned my parenting decision. Implied negligence.

BODY: Chest tightened. Warm face. Sat forward toward screen.
IMPULSE: Wanted to reply immediately with three paragraphs defending myself.
STORY: "They're building a case against me. This will be used in court."

Did I act from body/impulse?

[x] Mixed — paused for 2 minutes, then drafted reply. Sent after 20 min review.

What I did:

Waited 20 minutes, reread message, classified it as [P = Provocation] per situation literacy. Replied with two factual sentences only.

Token: Observer-stable — classified first, replied second.

Weekly pattern scan

Once a week, look at your log entries. Count:

Observer-stable entries: ____
Impulse entries: ____
Slipped on [____]: ____ (note which pattern appears most)

If one pattern appears 3+ times in a week — it goes into the drill schedule for that scenario type.

Integration

Impulse entries feed into [Six routing cards drill](#) — practice the specific scenario type that triggered the impulse.

Slipped-on patterns feed into [Cognitive distortion literacy](#) — verify which distortion was running.

Stable entries matter too — note which skill moved (pause, technique routing, breath anchor) so you can deliberately repeat it.

Phase — 04-cognitive-distortion-literacy

Directory: 04-cognitive-distortion-literacy/

Source: 04-cognitive-distortion-literacy/01-interpretive-traps-reading-minds-catastrophizing-absolutes.md

Five thinking errors that amplify conflict

What this is

Conflict rarely starts from the raw facts of a situation. It starts from the interpretation your mind puts on top of the facts — and under stress, that interpretation is often wrong in predictable ways.

These five thinking patterns are extremely common under pressure. They are not character flaws. They are habits the stressed mind defaults to. The skill is learning to name them when they are happening, so you can separate the interpretation from the fact before you act on it.

The five patterns

- 1. Mind-reading — assuming hostile intent without evidence** You receive an ambiguous message and decide what it means. “They’re saying this to undermine me.” “They’re doing this deliberately.” You treat the interpretation as fact.
- 2. Catastrophizing — running worst-case scenarios as if they are likely** One bad exchange becomes evidence that everything will collapse. One missed message becomes a pattern of deliberate neglect. The worst possible outcome feels not just possible but certain.
- 3. All-or-nothing thinking — everything is either perfect or completely ruined** A conversation that went mostly fine but had one rough moment becomes “I destroyed it.” A person who did one good thing does not get credit because they also did one bad thing.
- 4. Emotional reasoning — feeling equals fact** “I feel like they are trying to harm me, therefore they are.” The feeling is real. But a feeling is not evidence of the thing you feel.
- 5. Projection — assuming others have your motives** You find yourself attributing to others the exact fears or intentions you carry yourself. What you worry you might do, you assume they are already doing.

When to use this

- You are about to send a message written from a strong emotional conviction about what someone meant
- You notice a “they always” or “this proves” thought starting
- You feel certain about someone’s intentions but have not actually checked
- You want to review what happened in a conflict and understand your part in it clearly

How to do it

Five-column check: For any situation where an interpretation is driving your response, write: 1. What they said or did (exact words or actions, no interpretation) 2. The story you told yourself about it 3. Which of the five patterns is running 4. What you actually know for certain 5. One neutral question you could ask to check your interpretation

Review recent spirals: Think of six recent situations where your stress escalated. For each, label which pattern was present. Just label it — no prosecution of yourself. The goal is pattern recognition, not judgment.

Downgrade sentences: Practice saying out loud: “What I assumed was , *what I actually know is* .” Keep the tone flat — this is logistics, not victory or defeat.

Delay before concluding: When an ambiguous message arrives, the default is: delay 20 minutes, then ask one clarifying question rather than sending a response built on the interpretation.

Example

You send a message about a schedule change and get no reply for two days. Your mind says: "They're ignoring me deliberately. This is a pattern. They're trying to create problems."

Five-column check: - What happened: sent a message, no reply in two days - Story: deliberate, hostile, part of a pattern - Pattern: mind-reading + catastrophizing - What I know: they have not replied yet - Neutral question: "Did you see my message about the schedule?"

Connects to

- [Three biases that distort judgment under stress](#)
 - [Sitting with uncertainty](#)
 - [Noticing your body, impulse, and story separately](#)
-

Source: 04-cognitive-distortion-literacy/02-attribution-confirmation-availability-biases.md

Three biases that distort your judgment under stress

What this is

Beyond individual thinking errors, there are three deeper patterns that affect how your mind processes information when you are stressed or in conflict. They work quietly in the background, shaping what you notice, how you explain behaviour, and what conclusions feel obvious.

Naming them helps you catch them before they drive a decision or a message.

The three patterns

1. Blaming character instead of circumstances When someone does something that affects you negatively, the stressed mind jumps to: "that's just who they are" or "they did that because they are [hostile/selfish/dishonest]". It skips over the simpler explanation: they were under pressure, they misread the situation, they made a mistake.

You do not do this to yourself. When you behave badly, you explain it through circumstances: "I was exhausted", "I was under enormous pressure". Other people rarely get the same generous reading.

2. Confirmation bias — only noticing what fits the verdict Once you have formed a view about a person or situation, your mind preferentially notices evidence that confirms it and discounts or forgets evidence that contradicts it. This is not deliberate. It happens automatically.

The practical consequence: if you believe someone is out to get you, every ambiguous action becomes more evidence. Every cooperative action gets minimised or reframed.

3. Availability bias — the most vivid recent example feels like a universal rule The last difficult message, the last bad call, the last fight — these feel representative because they are fresh and emotionally charged. Your brain treats them as the whole picture, not one data point.

"They always do this" — usually based on two or three vivid recent examples, not an actual pattern.

When to use this

- After a conflict, before deciding what it means long-term
- When you are about to send something that starts with "you always" or "this proves"
- When you notice you cannot find anything positive to say about a person or situation
- When your judgments consistently get worse at night or at the end of a heavy week (check sleep and load first)

How to do it

Internal headline vs camera caption: For a recent friction, write two versions: - The internal headline — what your mind said happened ("they are deliberately making this difficult") - The camera caption — what an outside observer would say without interpretation ("they cancelled at two hours notice")

If the gap between these is large, do not send anything built on the headline.

Disconfirm search: Write one sentence of evidence against your current theory. It must be honest. If you genuinely cannot find any, write: “unknown — I have not looked for disconfirming evidence.”

Multiple possible motives: Instead of “they did it because X”, write: “possible reasons include , , ____.” Stop before choosing one. Unless you have actual evidence for one explanation, leave it plural.

Stress and sleep check: If your bias labels are spiking at night or after a difficult week, read the sleep and load file first. The same situation often reads completely differently when you are rested.

Example

A co-parent does not respond to a logistics message for 24 hours. Internal headline: “They’re ignoring me to create problems.” Camera caption: “24 hours without a response to a logistics message.” Disconfirm search: “They responded quickly to the last three messages about scheduling.”

Multiple motives: busy, phone issues, overwhelmed, didn’t see it, waiting for more information. Leave it there until there is actual evidence.

Connects to

- [Five thinking errors that amplify conflict](#)
 - [Sitting with uncertainty](#)
 - [Sleep and fatigue signals](#)
-

Source: 04-cognitive-distortion-literacy/03-uncertainty-tolerance-and-stress-amplification.md

Sitting with uncertainty — not forcing a resolution too soon

What this is

When something is unresolved, the discomfort of not knowing is real. The urge to resolve it — to get an answer, to decide what it means, to send the message that will force a conclusion — is also real. But acting on that urge too quickly often creates a second problem on top of the original one.

This file is about two related things:

1. **Sitting with “I don’t know yet”** without immediately forcing a resolution
2. **Stress amplification** — the way stress makes threats feel bigger and more urgent than they actually are, which makes the urge to resolve even harder to resist

When to use this

- You are waiting for a response and interpreting the silence in the worst possible way
- You feel the urge to send a message that would force a resolution before you have enough information
- You keep returning to an unresolved situation and cannot leave it alone
- You know rationally that you should wait but cannot hold yourself back from acting

How to do it

Step 1 — Name your specific uncertainty triggers.

List five situations where uncertainty is hardest for you personally. Examples: no reply for more than a day, not knowing how a formal process is going, ambiguous logistics around schedules. For each one, write one honest sentence you can actually say or think: “I’ll answer once I’ve verified the details.” The sentence needs to be true — a real commitment to a real timeline.

Step 2 — Ninety-second urge surf.

When the urge to act (send the message, force the conclusion, reopen the conflict) spikes: - Set a timer for 90 seconds - Do nothing during those 90 seconds - Note whether the urgency actually changes

This is practice. The goal is not to eliminate the urge. The goal is to see that the urge rises and falls on its own without you acting on it. Do this twice a week on real situations.

Step 3 — Night rule.

If history shows that you read messages worse after a certain hour — set a cutoff. No conflict threads after that time. This is not avoidance. It is accurate scheduling: you are not better at resolving things at 11pm than at 9am, and the evidence in your message history probably shows that.

Step 4 — Notice stress amplification in your body.

Stress amplification has physical signals — heat in the face or chest, tunnel vision, a sense of urgency that feels physical. When you notice these, run the grounding reset (feet, jaw, slow breath out) before re-engaging with the uncertain situation. The urgency is partly your nervous system, not purely the facts of the situation.

Step 5 — Protect recovery time deliberately.

Prolonged uncertainty is exhausting. This is not a weakness — it is a cost. Schedule recovery blocks explicitly, especially during periods when multiple things are unresolved at once.

Example

It is 10pm. You sent a message about a schedule change hours ago and have not heard back. You have now checked the message six times. You are composing a follow-up that will likely escalate things.

Ninety-second urge surf: set the timer, put the phone down. Notice the urgency. After 90 seconds, ask: do I have new information? No. Is sending a follow-up now likely to help? No. Set the phone down. Come back to it tomorrow morning.

Connects to

- [Five thinking errors that amplify conflict](#)
 - [Three biases that distort judgment under stress](#)
 - [Recognising when you are off and how to reset](#)
 - [Decision fatigue and energy budgeting](#)
-

Phase — 05-communication-under-pressure

Directory: [05-communication-under-pressure/](#)

Source: [05-communication-under-pressure/01-golden-chain-pause-structure-silence.md](#)

Pause, say less, stop — the core communication habit

What this is

When you are under pressure, the instinct is to keep talking — to fill the silence, add more context, explain one more thing. This habit works against you. It makes you harder to listen to, easier to interrupt, and more likely to say something you did not mean to say.

The habit to build instead is simple: pause before you speak, answer in short chunks of one to three sentences, then stop and wait. Silence after you finish is not a problem. It is not a signal that you said something wrong. It is just silence.

When to use this

- In any formal setting: a meeting, a hearing, an evaluation, a difficult conversation
- When someone asks you a question and you feel the urge to give a long answer
- When anxiety is making you want to fill every quiet moment with words
- When you notice yourself saying “...and another thing”

How to do it

Step 1 — Before you answer: Take at least two seconds before speaking. Do not fill that gap with filler sounds. Just pause. Use the time to decide what you actually want to say.

Step 2 — Answer in chunks: Give your answer in one to three sentences. Then stop. Do not add more. Do not qualify everything. Do not explain what you just said. Say it, then close your mouth.

Step 3 — Sit with the silence: After you stop talking, wait. The other person will respond or ask a follow-up question. You do not need to rescue the moment. Remind yourself: silence is not failure, it is just a pause.

Step 4 — Kill “...and another thing”: This phrase is the enemy. Every time you feel it coming, catch it and stop. If something is important, it can be its own answer when asked, not a tail you attach to the previous one.

Example

Someone asks: “Why didn’t you respond to that message earlier this week?”

Bad version: “Well I was dealing with a lot and I wasn’t sure what to say and honestly I didn’t want to make things worse and I thought maybe if I waited things would settle down and also I wasn’t sure if it was even my place to respond and...”

Good version: “I needed some time to think before responding.” Then stop.

Connects to

- [Three-part answer structure](#) — for when the answer genuinely needs more shape
 - [Observer loop](#) — for noticing when you are in reactive mode
 - [Cognitive distortion literacy](#) — for understanding what anxiety does to your thinking
-

Structuring a complex answer — opening, substance, close

What this is

Some answers need a little more shape than just a direct reply. For those, you can use a simple three-part structure: a brief orienting phrase that sets up what you are about to say, the actual answer, and a grounding close that points forward rather than backward.

The important thing is to know when NOT to use it. Most of the time, the answer alone is enough. Forcing this structure onto every response makes you sound rehearsed and unnatural. Use it when the question is complex and a bare answer would leave things unclear.

When to use this

- When a question requires a longer answer and you want to stay organised
- When you need to give a nuanced response without wandering
- When you want to end on something concrete rather than leaving things open
- Do NOT use this for simple, direct questions — just answer those directly

How to do it

Part 1 — Opening phrase (optional): One short sentence that orients the listener before you go into your answer. Its job is to signal what kind of answer is coming, not to pad the response. Examples: “To be precise about what happened...” or “There are two parts to this...”

Part 2 — The actual answer: This is the core. State the facts, your position, or what you know. Keep it tight. This is the part that matters.

Part 3 — Grounding close (optional): End with something that looks forward or anchors the conversation. This prevents the answer from trailing off into vagueness. Examples: “What I can commit to from here is...” or “The next step on my end is...”

Check before you speak: Ask yourself: does this answer actually need an opening phrase? Does it need a closing line? If not, drop them. The answer alone is usually enough.

Example

Question: “What’s your plan for handling communication going forward?”

Without structure (fine for a simple version): “I’m keeping exchanges brief and in writing.”

With structure (when more context is needed): “To be clear about what I’m changing — I’m keeping all communication in writing and limiting it to logistics. What I can commit to is responding within 24 hours on anything related to the kids.”

Connects to

- [Pause and silence habit](#) — pacing applies inside this structure too

Six response types — and how to handle stacked accusations

What this is

Under pressure, your brain wants to improvise. It mashes together moralising, defending, explaining, and counter-attacking all at once. The result is usually a mess that makes things worse.

Instead, learn to recognise which type of response the situation actually calls for, pick that one, and use only that one. There are six types. Each has a specific job.

The six response types

#	When to use it
1	The question is narrow and factual — just answer it directly
2	The question involves someone else's behaviour or wellbeing — redirect toward what you can do, especially around care for children or dependents
3	The question is vague or too broad — ask for precision before answering
4	You only know part of the answer — confirm what you know, say nothing beyond that
5	You are not the right person or channel for this — say so and redirect
6	The question contains a false or harmful assumption — refuse to accept the premise

The rule: use one technique per response. Do not stack them. When you are anxious, the temptation is to use all six at once. That is the mistake.

How to handle stacked accusations

When someone layers multiple accusations on top of each other — especially in formal or emotionally charged situations — use this three-step sequence:

Step 1 — Refuse the premise: Do not accept the accusation as a starting point. Name that you are not accepting it. Example: “That framing does not reflect what actually happened.”

Step 2 — State your boundary: Say clearly what you will and will not address. Example: “I’m not going to respond to characterisations I don’t recognise. What I can speak to is what I did.”

Step 3 — Redirect forward: Move toward something concrete and constructive. Example: “What matters now is how we handle the next step.”

Keep this short. The whole thing should take under fifteen seconds. Deliver it calmly, without matching the tone of the accusation.

When to use this

- You receive a question and feel the urge to answer with everything at once
- Someone is stacking multiple attacks or accusations in one message
- You are in a formal or evaluative setting where improvising is risky
- You have just been hit with something provocative and need a structured way to respond

Example

Accusation: “You’ve always been impossible to deal with, you ignored every message, and now you expect everyone to trust you?”

Step 1 — Refuse premise: “I’m not going to accept that summary.” Step 2 — Boundary: “I’ll speak to my actual actions, not a generalisation.” Step 3 — Forward: “What I’ve done since [date] is [specific behaviour]. That’s what I can account for.”

Connects to

- [Message classification](#) — classifying the message before picking a technique
 - [Pause and silence habit](#) — slowing down enough to pick the right technique
-

Physical presence in difficult conversations

What this is

When you are anxious or under attack, your body shows it before you say a word. Your pace speeds up, your shoulders rise, your eyes either dart away or lock on too hard, and small nervous habits leak through — a dismissive exhale, a tense laugh, a sudden gesture.

People in evaluative or hostile settings read your body at least as much as they read your words. A calm, steady physical presence reinforces what you are saying. Nervous, defensive body language undermines it, even when your words are exactly right.

When to use this

- Before any formal conversation, hearing, or evaluation
- When you are rehearsing how to handle a difficult exchange
- After reviewing a recording of yourself and noticing something you want to change

How to do it

Before or during a difficult conversation, run through this checklist mentally:

1. **Pace** — speak slower than you naturally would when anxious. When nerves kick in, people speed up. Slow is calm.
2. **Shoulders** — drop them away from your ears. Tension lives there. Lower them deliberately.
3. **Hands** — keep them visible and still. No gripping, no fidgeting, no sudden gestures.
4. **Eyes** — maintain normal, human eye contact. Not a stare, not the floor. Look at the person, look away briefly, look back. Normal.
5. **Silence** — do not fill pauses with sounds. No “um,” no exhale, no nervous laugh. Let silence be silence.
6. **No dismissive reactions** — no eye-rolls, no sighs of contempt, no snort-laughs. These invite escalation and they are remembered. If you feel the urge, breathe instead.

Practice

Record yourself answering a simple, neutral question for about 30 seconds. Then watch it back and check only the six items above — not your words, just your body and pace. If something fails, repeat and focus on that one thing.

If you have one chronic habit you want to remove — a dismissive exhale, a nervous laugh, an eye-roll — replace it with something specific: a slow blink, a soft jaw, one quiet breath. Practice that replacement daily for a week until it becomes the automatic response instead.

Connects to

- [Pause and silence habit](#) — pacing connects directly to this
-

Phase — 06-situation-literacy

Directory: `06-situation-literacy/`

Source: `06-situation-literacy/01-classifying-messages-information-provocation-hooks.md`

Read the message before you react — three types to know

What this is

Not every message that lands hard is asking for information. Some are designed to trigger an emotional reaction. Some are trying to pull you into a story someone else wrote. If you respond to all of them the same way — by defending yourself or explaining — you will almost always make things worse.

Before you respond to anything, classify what it actually is. There are three types:

- **I — Information:** A genuine request for facts or a straightforward question. Answer it directly.
- **P — Provocation:** Designed to make you angry, defensive, or reactive. Responding emotionally is exactly what it wants. Use a structured technique instead.
- **H — Hook:** Inviting you into a narrative or storyline you did not author. Accepting the framing means you are already playing on someone else's terms.

Classification comes before response. You do not reply until you know what you are dealing with.

When to use this

- You receive a message that hits you and you have an impulse to reply immediately
- You are reviewing a transcript or thread before deciding how to respond
- You are in a conversation where the questions feel designed to corner you
- Multiple questions are coming at once and you feel overwhelmed

How to do it

Step 1 — Read or hear the message once. Do not respond.

Step 2 — Assign a label: I, P, or H. Ask yourself: Is this genuinely asking for information? Or is it trying to get a reaction? Or is it framing me inside a story I did not agree to?

Step 3 — Route to the right response. - I messages: answer directly and simply - P messages: use the refusal-of-premise technique or a factual boundary statement - H messages: narrow it down to specific facts, or decline to engage with the narrative

Step 4 — If multiple questions are stacked, slow down. Say “one at a time” and answer one, then stop. Do not try to address everything at once.

Example

Message received: “You never cared about any of this until it became convenient for you.”

Classification: P — this is a provocation, not a question. There is no information being requested. It is designed to produce a defensive reaction.

Response: Do not defend, do not explain your history, do not mirror the emotional charge. Instead: “That’s not how I see it. What specifically are you asking about?”

Connects to

- [Six response techniques](#) — where to route P and H messages
 - [Ambiguous and leading questions](#) — a specific subset of H messages
 - [Cognitive distortion literacy](#)
-

Questions with hidden assumptions — how to handle them

What this is

Some questions are not really questions. They contain a built-in assumption, and if you answer the question as asked, you have already accepted the assumption. This is how leading questions work.

The classic example: “When did you stop being angry all the time?” The question assumes you were angry all the time. If you answer it — even to deny it — you are debating on those terms. The right move is to identify the hidden assumption and refuse to accept it before you say anything else.

The same applies to hypothetical scenarios: “If it turned out you had done X, wouldn’t you have to admit that Y?” You did not agree to the premise. You do not owe an answer to a hypothetical you never accepted.

When to use this

- A question feels like it has already decided something about you
- You notice the question assumes something that is not true
- Someone asks you to respond to a hypothetical scenario as if it were established fact
- You feel pressure to defend yourself against a framing you do not recognise

How to do it

Step 1 — Identify the hidden assumption. Before you answer, ask yourself: what is this question taking for granted? Say it internally: “This question assumes that...”

Step 2 — Narrow the question down. Instead of accepting the framing and defending yourself within it, bring the conversation back to specifics. Useful phrases: - “Which specific instance are you referring to?” - “What timeframe are you asking about?” - “Can you be more precise about what you mean by that?”

Narrowing is not evasion. It is refusing to debate something that has not been established.

Step 3 — For hypotheticals, decline to build the scenario. You do not have to construct an answer to an imaginary situation you never agreed to. A clean response: “I’m not going to speculate about a scenario I don’t recognise. What actually happened is...”

Step 4 — Watch your recordings. If you are practising, review what you said. The thing to catch is any sentence that starts with “yeah, I guess if that were true...” — that is you accepting the premise. That sentence should not be there.

Example

Question: “Why do you always make everything about yourself?”

Hidden assumption: that you always do this.

Wrong response: “I don’t always do that, sometimes I’m very considerate and here are three examples...” (You accepted the framing and are now defending yourself inside it.)

Right response: “I don’t recognise that as a pattern. Is there something specific you want to talk about?”

Connects to

- [Message classification](#) — leading questions are usually H or P messages
 - [Channel routing](#) — when precision alone would expose something sensitive, route to writing or advisor
 - [Cognitive distortion literacy](#)
-

Message classification drill — I · P · H routing practice

Practice before the real messages arrive. 30 lines, solo, 15–20 minutes. Goal: classification reflex under 2 seconds.

Classification system

Tag	Stands for	What it is
I	Inform	Genuine request for factual information or logistics
P	Provoke	Designed to trigger emotional response — correct answer is no insult mirror
H	Hook	Invites you into a narrative or story frame you didn't author and shouldn't defend

Drill procedure

Step 1. Read each line below. Do not answer it. Assign only I / P / H.

Step 2. After tagging all 30, go back and for P and H items: pick one routing card (1–6) per item.

Step 3. For your toughest 5–8 items: speak the tag aloud + routing digit within 2 seconds of re-reading.

Routing card reference (from Six routing cards)

#	Use when...
1	Narrowly scoped factual — answer directly, briefly
2	Redirect to child/care-forward without psychoanalyzing absent parties
3	Precision — tighten a vague or bombardment question
4	Partial witness — you can confirm a fact, but not the full accusation
5	Channel redirect — this belongs to a different person or process
6	Refuse the premise — the question assumes something you do not accept

Drill set A — low to medium intensity

Classify each (I / P / H) and, for P and H, add routing digit.

1. "What time does pick-up happen on Saturday?"
2. "You always make everything about yourself."
3. "Everyone can see what kind of person you really are."
4. "Did you confirm the appointment with the doctor?"
5. "Why do you think the children are happy with you?"
6. "Can you send me the school schedule for next month?"
7. "After everything I've done, this is how you behave."
8. "What does your therapist say about your anger issues?"
9. "I need the insurance documents by end of week."
10. "You were always the difficult one in the relationship."

Drill set B — medium to high intensity

1. "Have you explained to the children why we are in this situation?"
2. "Don't you think the children deserve a stable parent?"
3. "I'm just asking a simple question — why can't you answer it?"

4. "What time will you be back with the children on Sunday?"
 5. "Your behavior in the last meeting was embarrassing for everyone."
 6. "Is it true that you told the children X?" (where X is false)
 7. "How much do you earn per month currently?"
 8. "My parents are worried about the children's wellbeing."
 9. "Why do you think you're a better parent than I am?"
 10. "I need written confirmation of the arrangement we discussed."
-

Drill set C — sustained pressure and combined patterns

1. "You did X, then Y, then Z — don't you see the pattern?" (multiple accusations stacked)
 2. "The children told me what happened. I think we both know the truth."
 3. "Can we just talk like adults for once?"
 4. "What's your plan for the summer holidays?"
 5. "Everyone who knows you says the same thing."
 6. "I'm not angry. I just want to understand why you chose to do that."
 7. "Don't you feel guilty?"
 8. "What are your thoughts on joint custody going forward?"
 9. "You know this is going to come up in the proceedings."
 10. "I'm doing this for the children. I hope you can say the same."
-

Answer key (sample — your judgment may differ)

#	Tag	Routing (P/H only)
1	I	—
2	P	6 (refuse premise — “always” is not accurate)
3	P	6 (refuse premise — “everyone” is not a source)
4	I	—
5	H	2 (care-forward redirect)
6	I	—
7	P	6 (refuse premise)
8	H	4 (partial witness + 5 channel redirect)
9	I	—
10	P	6
11	H	2
12	H	2 + 6
13	P	3 (precision — what is the question exactly?)
14	I	—
15	P	6
16	P/H	4 (partial witness — you can address what you know is factual)
17	I or P	depends on context — answer factually if legally relevant
18	H	2
19	H	6 (refuse comparative framing)
20	I	—
21	P/H	3 (precision) + 6 (refuse compound accusation)
22	H	4 (partial witness — you cannot verify what was said to them)
23	P	3 (precision — “like adults” is not a standard)
24	I	—
25	P	6
26	P	6 (the framing is not neutral — observe the body channel first)
27	P/H	6
28	I/H	depends — answer factually if safe to do so
29	P	4 (you note the comment, you do not engage with the threat)
30	H	2

Weekly rotation rule

Do not drill the same set twice in a row. Rotate: A → B → C → A.

After each session: log one line — which item was hardest and why.

Pattern: if the same item type appears hard repeatedly → it identifies the scenario cluster to rehearse in [Integration layer](#).

Phase — 07-audiences-channels-boundaries

Directory: [07-audiences-channels-boundaries/](#)

Source: [07-audiences-channels-boundaries/01-channel-routing-and-two-world-model.md](#)

What you say live vs what goes in writing — keep them separate

What this is

There are two different worlds for what you communicate, and they have different rules.

Live conversation — phone calls, in-person exchanges, verbal responses in meetings or hearings. These are judged on tone, composure, and brevity. Keep them short, factual, and calm. Do not try to argue a complex case from memory in a live setting.

Written and official channels — emails, formal statements, legal documents, anything on the record. These can be reviewed, edited, and are permanent. Everything here needs to be precise, considered, and checked before it goes out. Nothing is improvised.

The danger is mixing them up. The most common mistake is trying to rebuild a complex argument live — from memory, under stress — when that argument belongs in writing with proper review. The improvised version is almost always worse than the written version, and it cannot be taken back.

When to use this

- You are about to respond to something legally or formally significant in a live conversation
- You feel the urge to “just explain everything” verbally when the topic is serious
- You are deciding whether to respond now (live/verbal) or wait and put it in writing
- Something sensitive comes up in a conversation and you are not sure what to say

How to do it

Before you speak, ask: does this belong in writing?

Things that belong in the live channel: - Brief, factual statements about your own observable behaviour - Simple logistical responses you know with certainty - Calm, composed tone — no drama, no lengthy arguments

Things that belong in writing or with an advisor: - Anything involving legal details or formal positions - Complex explanations of past events - Anything you are not certain about - Anything where the exact wording matters

When something sensitive comes up live that belongs in writing: You do not have to answer it on the spot. Say: “That’s something I want to address properly — I’ll put it in writing.” Then stop.

Never try to reconstruct a formal argument from memory under pressure. If you are not sure, say you will follow up in writing. That is always the safer choice.

Example

You are in a meeting and someone asks: “Can you explain exactly what happened in the incident on [date] and why you responded the way you did?”

This is not a live-conversation answer. The details matter too much to improvise.

Live response: “That’s something I want to address accurately. I’ll put a clear account in writing.”

Connects to

- [Starve the anxiety loop](#)
 - [Leading and ambiguous questions](#)
-

When engaging makes things worse — learning to stop feeding the loop

What this is

Some conversations, people, and channels get worse the more you engage with them. Every response you add becomes more material. Every explanation invites another challenge. Every clarification gets used as a new angle of attack.

Anxiety pushes you to engage. It feels like if you just explain one more thing, clarify one more misunderstanding, or correct one more false claim, things will get better. They usually do not. Anxiety mistakes verbosity for control.

The discipline here is recognising the difference between two things: - Responding because it is genuinely necessary - Responding because the silence is uncomfortable and you cannot sit with it

The second one is where the damage happens.

When to use this

- You have already said what needed to be said and feel the urge to add more
- You are in a thread or exchange that gets more hostile the more you engage
- You just hit send and are now composing the follow-up message
- Someone is not responding and you are about to fill the silence with more words
- You notice yourself replying in long messages to short provocations

How to do it

Step 1 — Name the pattern. Look at five things you have said or written in the past that were driven by anxiety rather than necessity. What did they add? In most cases, they added length but not substance, and they gave the other person more to respond to.

Step 2 — Write one replacement line for each. For each over-explanation, find one sentence that covers the essential point and nothing more. Practice saying it out loud.

Step 3 — Sit with the discomfort. When the urge to explain yourself hits, do not respond for at least two minutes. Notice the urge. It will peak and then soften. You do not need to act on every urge to explain.

Step 4 — Check your CC lists and forward habits. Adding more people to a thread, forwarding messages to create a record, or cc-ing others as a form of pressure — these usually escalate things. Ask before you add anyone: does this serve the outcome, or does it serve my anxiety?

Step 5 — After answering, stop. No postscripts. No “just one more thing.” Once you have said what needed to be said, close the conversation and leave it.

Example

You send a message. You do not get a response for two days. You feel the urge to send a follow-up: “Just checking in to make sure you got this — I want to be clear that I wasn’t trying to imply...”

Stop. The follow-up is being driven by anxiety about how the first message landed, not by any genuine need. Do not send it.

Connects to

- [Channel routing](#)
-

Phase — 08-behaviour-as-signal

Directory: `08-behaviour-as-signal/`

Source: `08-behaviour-as-signal/01-internal-filter-no-catalog-no-performance-self-work-talk.md`

Answering “what are you doing to stay grounded?” — without performing

What this is

In formal, evaluative, or court-adjacent settings, someone may ask what you are doing to work on yourself, stay stable, or be a better parent. How you answer this matters more than most people realise.

The instinct is to list things — apps, courses, books, coaches, frameworks. This reads as performance. It sounds like someone auditioning rather than someone who is actually grounded. Evaluators notice this.

The right answer is short, behaviour-focused, and centred on how it helps you show up for the people who depend on you — especially children. No catalogue, no jargon, no self-promotion dressed up as humility.

When to use this

- You are asked in a formal or evaluative setting about your self-work or personal development
- You are preparing for a custody evaluation, mediation, or any institutional review
- You want to practise what you would actually say if asked this question

How to do it

Keep it to one answer, not a list. Pick the one thing that is most true and most relevant to being a steady parent or dependable person. Say that.

Make it behaviour-focused. Not “I’ve been learning about emotional regulation” — but “I’m working on staying calmer when things get tense, especially around the kids.”

Centre it on the child or dependent. The evaluator wants to know what this means for the people who depend on you. Not what it means for your personal growth.

Say only what is true. Do not claim practices you do not have. Do not add things to make the list sound more serious.

What to leave out: - Apps and digital tools - Course completions or certificates - Books you have read - Therapy terminology or brand names - Anything that sounds like “I have a system” - Long personal history nobody asked for

Five example answers

Pick the one that fits your situation and adapt it to your own words. Do not read all five aloud.

1. “I’m working on staying calmer and more consistent under pressure — especially when something involves the kids.”
2. “I try to keep adult conflict away from the children and keep our routines steady.”
3. “When things get stressful I’m practising shorter, clearer responses so I’m more reliable for them.”
4. “I’m focused on what the kids actually need from me day to day — predictability and a calm tone.”
5. “I do some physical activity to stay even — it helps me show up more steadily as a parent.”

The short rule

If you are stuck, ask yourself: is this answer true, relevant to the child, and free of self-promotion? If yes, say it. If not, cut it.

Connects to

- [Two registers — private vs shareable](#)

Source: 08-behaviour-as-signal/02-two-registers-internal-speech-vs-shareable.md

Private thoughts vs what you actually say — keeping them separate

What this is

Your internal experience can be angry, raw, and extreme. That is fine. That is where it belongs. The mistake is when that raw internal voice leaks into what you write or say to others — especially in writing, which is permanent, and especially anywhere near children or formal settings.

The goal is not to suppress how you feel. It is to translate it. Raw emotion is useful input for understanding what is happening. It is not useful as output, because it lands differently than it was intended, and it can cause harm that outlasts the moment that produced it.

There are two registers:

- **Private register:** candid, unfiltered, for your journal, your therapy session, or your own processing. You can say anything here.
- **Outward register:** calm, factual, purposeful. Not fake warmth — just workable precision. This is what goes into messages, formal exchanges, and anything that could be read by a child, an evaluator, or a court.

When to use this

- You are about to send a message while angry or hurt
- You are reviewing something you wrote and it feels too hot
- You want to practise translating a strong internal reaction into a usable response
- Something happened and you need to respond formally but feel the raw version surfacing

How to do it

Step 1 — Write the raw version privately. Get the actual feeling out somewhere that is not a message to anyone. Paper, a private note, or spoken aloud to yourself. Let it be ugly.

Step 2 — Identify the strategic core. Underneath the emotion, what do you actually need to communicate? Strip away the feeling and find the fact or the request.

Step 3 — Write the outward version. Same strategic goal. Different words. No cruelty, no blame language, no exaggeration. Factual and purposeful.

Step 4 — Review before sending. Read the message as if you were someone else — an evaluator, a mediator, or your child reading it in ten years. Does it communicate what matters? Does it contain anything that would look bad to an outside reader? If yes, revise.

Example

Raw internal version: “She’s doing this on purpose to make me look bad and I’m sick of being treated like I’m nothing.”

Strategic core: there is a logistics issue that needs to be resolved.

Outward version: “I want to make sure we’re aligned on the pick-up time. Can we confirm it is [time] on [date]?”

The feeling is valid. The outward version serves the actual goal.

The boundary

Feeling something intense does not make it appropriate to send. Calling it “authentic” or “honest” does not justify writing something cruel, especially in any channel where a child could read it. The internal register is yours. The outward register affects other people.

Connects to

- [Self-work talk — no performance](#)
 - [Measurable stability signals](#)
-

Source: 08-behaviour-as-signal/03-measurable-stability-and-caregiving-signals-appendix.md

What stability actually looks like — behaviours others can observe

What this is

Stability is not a feeling. It is not something you claim. It is a set of behaviours that other people can see and verify over time. Evaluators, judges, and anyone watching you in a caregiving role will judge stability by what you do consistently — not by what you say about yourself.

This file helps you identify those behaviours, rate yourself honestly on them, and pick one specific thing to improve this week.

What counts as observable stability

These are the kinds of behaviours that register with outside observers:

- Arriving on time — to pickups, appointments, school events
- Keeping children out of adult conflict — not discussing the other parent negatively in front of them, not asking them to carry messages
- Maintaining a calm tone under stress — especially in exchanges with the other parent or in formal settings
- Consistent routines — bedtimes, meals, school preparation, homework
- Following through on what you say you will do
- Responding to communications promptly and without escalation
- Keeping formal exchanges brief, factual, and free of blame

How to do it

Step 1 — Rate yourself honestly. Go through the list above (or build your own version). For each behaviour, give yourself an honest score: - 0 = I am not doing this at all - 1 = I do this sometimes, inconsistently - 2 = I do this most of the time - 3 = I do this reliably

Be honest. No one is reading this except you, and inflation here only hurts you.

Step 2 — Pick one behaviour to improve this week. Not three. Not everything at once. One. The one where a small, consistent improvement would be most visible or most meaningful.

Step 3 — Define what “better” looks like. Make it specific. Not “I’ll be calmer” but “When I receive a message that provokes me, I will wait 20 minutes before responding.” Concrete and testable.

Step 4 — Check next week. Did you do the thing you said? If yes, pick the next one. If no, investigate why, not as self-criticism, but as information.

Spoken version (for evaluative settings)

If you are asked to describe what you provide as a caregiver, keep it practical and short. One minute or less. Describe what the child actually receives from you: predictability, a calm environment, consistency. Mention one real, specific moment if it helps. Then stop.

No melodrama. No “I would do anything for my child.” Just what you actually do, described plainly.

Connects to

- [Self-work talk — no performance](#)
- [Two registers — private vs shareable](#)

Phase — 09-daily-mechanics

Directory: 09-daily-mechanics/

Source: 09-daily-mechanics/01-universal-micro-ritual.md

Morning micro-ritual — three breaths, a number, one move

What this is

Before you start your first serious interaction of the day — a message, a meeting, a difficult call — you do three things that take under a minute. This is not meditation or self-help theatre. It is a small act that prevents you from going into high-stakes moments cold, reactive, and improvised.

The three things are: three slow breaths, a stress number, and one concrete action for the day.

When to use this

Every morning, before your first significant interaction. That means before you reply to anything charged, before a difficult call, before a meeting that matters.

How to do it

Step 1 — Three breaths. Breathe in slowly, breathe out slowly. Do that three times. That is it.

Step 2 — Name your stress level. Give today a number from 1 to 5. Do not overthink it. Just say the number to yourself. 1 is calm. 5 is close to the edge.

Step 3 — Name one achievable action for today. Pick something specific and completable. Not a vague intention. A real thing: send a message, make a call, write one paragraph, go for a walk. It needs to be something you can mark as done by end of day.

Track your streak. Each day you complete the ritual before your first serious interaction, mark it. The streak number matters more than how you feel about it. Aim for seven days in a row before you consider skipping.

Example

You wake up, check your phone, and see a message that makes your stomach tighten. Before you respond: put the phone down. Three breaths. You give the day a 3. You name your one action: “Send the logistics email by noon.” Now you can respond.

Connects to

- ../01-operational-stance/04-three-layer-operational-mantra.md
 - ../11-reflection-evening-loop/01-three-evening-review-questions.md
-

Source: 09-daily-mechanics/02-morning-protocol-card.md

Morning protocol card — daily operational start

Complete before first heavy contact of the day. Entire sequence: under 5 minutes.

Sequence

1. Triple breath (30 seconds)

Three slow breaths, each one longer than the previous. On the third exhale: shoulders drop, jaw unclenches.

Not meditation. Not a ritual you perform beautifully. A mechanical reset.

2. Stress digit (15 seconds)

Pick a number 1–5 right now:

- 1 = rested, clear, no background noise
- 2 = slightly tired or something low-grade running
- 3 = elevated – some stress present, manageable
- 4 = high load – external pressure, sleep deficit, conflict active
- 5 = overwhelmed or dysregulated – system is hot

Say the number aloud. Write it if you have a log.

If 4 or 5: today is a managed day, not a performance day. Adjust commitments accordingly. Do not pretend the number is lower.

3. Single reachable action (60 seconds)

Complete this sentence:

“Today, one bounded thing I will do is ___.”

Rules for the sentence: - Observable: you can verify by end of day whether it happened - Reachable: possible with current energy level - Not abstract: “be calm” is not it. “Send that message before lunch” is.

Write it down or say it aloud. Both work. The act of stating it matters more than the medium.

Daily log (optional, high-value if maintained)

Date: _____
Stress digit: _____
One action: _____
Completed by EOD: Yes / No / Partial

Streak target: complete this before first serious contact on 7 consecutive days. After that it becomes background. Before that — track it mechanically.

Trigger map

If stress digit is...	Then...
1–2	Normal day, full engagement available
3	Useful signal. Note what’s running. No action change needed.
4	Lighten scheduled commitments where possible. No difficult communications without preparation.
5	Reschedule non-urgent high-stakes interactions. Protect recovery window.

Integration

The action sentence links to [Three-layer operational mantra](#).

The stress digit feeds into [Evening review template](#) — compare morning digit to evening one. Pattern over weeks shows load trends before they become emergencies.

Phase — 10-drills-and-exercise-archive

Directory: `10-drills-and-exercise-archive/`

Source: `10-drills-and-exercise-archive/01-integration-layer-scenario-loops.md`

Practice drills — rotating scenario clusters

What this is

Reading about communication skills does not make them stick. Practicing them does. This file holds the set of scenario types you rotate through each week. The rule is simple: the number of scenarios you actually practice must be higher than the number of new pages you read.

When to use this

Every week. Pick one cluster, do the minimum reps, log whether you did them or skipped.

The scenario clusters

Rotate through these over time:

- **Provocation and accusations** — someone attacks, accuses, or provokes you. Practice short responses with no insult back and a breath between sentences.
- **Written conflict** — chat messages and emails that are hostile or ambiguous. Practice responding with fewer words, no reactive paragraphs, only bounded facts.
- **Communication under time pressure** — you have very little time to decide. Practice making a partial deal or holding a firm position without leaking leverage.
- **Institutional and formal tone** — official settings, formal letters, proceedings. Practice staying calm and factual when the stakes feel high.
- **Warmth and contact** — practice being genuinely present and warm without performing it.
- **Crisis response** — when something feels overwhelming or frozen. Practice naming one next step and separating real threats from imagined ones.

How to do it

Each week: 1. Pick one cluster from the list above. 2. Do the minimum reps — say the scenarios aloud, write the responses, or role-play them. 3. Log one line: done or skipped. No essay required.

After each session: Write one sentence naming which specific skill moved during that session. For example: “I paused before responding instead of matching the other person’s tone.”

Weekly check: Count how many scenarios you practiced versus how many new pages you read. Scenarios practiced should be the higher number.

Connects to

- `../03-observer-loop/` — pair noisy sessions with observer loop material
 - `../02-regulation-and-recovery/` — if a session activates you, go to regulation work first
-

Source: `10-drills-and-exercise-archive/02-weekly-drill-schedule.md`

Weekly drill schedule — minimum viable reps

One scenario cluster per week. Complete its minimum reps. Log done/skipped — no essay required.

Design principle

Attempted scenarios must outrun fresh pages skimmed. Reading new material gives the feeling of progress. Drilling old material produces the actual progress.

Minimum viable session: **10–15 minutes**. If you have 30 — extend the hard items, don't add a new cluster.

Weekly cycle (4-week rotation)

Week 1 — Message classification + observer labelling

Goal: classification reflex under 2 seconds, observer-stable log from at least one real contact.

Day	Activity	Time	Log
Mon	Drill Set A — Message Classification	15 min	Done / Skipped
Wed	Drill Set B — same drill	15 min	Done / Skipped
Thu–Fri	Fill Observer daily log after one real contact	5 min	Done / Skipped
Sun	Weekly observer log scan — count observer-stable vs impulse	5 min	Done / Skipped

Week 1 minimum: 2 drill sessions + 1 observer log entry.

Week 2 — Communication under pressure: pause and structure

Goal: 2-second gap before first word, no filler syllables, 3-sentence limit per turn.

Day	Activity	Time	Log
Mon	Solo spoken reps — read 10 prompts from Set B aloud, pause 2 sec before each answer	10 min	Done / Skipped
Wed	Partner or voice-recorded session — 6 prompts, answer in 1–3 sentences max, then stop	15 min	Done / Skipped
Thu–Fri	Apply in one real interaction — note where silence felt uncomfortable	—	Note: __
Sun	Review: how many times did “...and another thing” or filler appear this week?	5 min	Count: __

Week 2 minimum: 1 solo rep session + 1 application in real contact.

Week 3 — Sustained pressure and compound accusations (Drill Set C)

Goal: refuse premises cleanly without mirroring insult, route compound accusations to single focus.

Day	Activity	Time	Log
Mon	Drill Set C — classify and route all 10 items	15 min	Done / Skipped
Wed	Spoken triad practice on 6 items: refuse premise → boundary sentence → behavioural pivot	15 min	Done / Skipped
Thu–Fri	If a difficult message arrives this week: classify before replying. Log it.	—	Done / Skipped
Sun	Note: which item type in Set C was hardest? Add to next week's hard-item list.	5 min	Item: __

Week 3 minimum: 1 classification session + spoken triads on at least 3 items.

Week 4 — Integration and reset loop

Goal: run a full simulated interaction from start (observer pre-state) through contact through post-contact log.

Day	Activity	Time	Log
Mon	Morning protocol (stress digit + action sentence) — log it	3 min	Digit: __
Mon– Fri	Evening review template — 3 questions daily	5 min/ day	Streak: __/ 5
Wed	Simulated heavy contact: partner reads from drill set C + D (create your own hard set), you respond live with: observe → route → 1–3 sentences → stop	20 min	Done / Skipped
Fri	Post-contact observer log from the simulated session	5 min	Done / Skipped
Sun	Month review: which skill moved most? What’s the hardest remaining cluster?	10 min	Skill: __

Week 4 minimum: 5-day evening review streak + 1 full simulated session.

Quarterly recalibration

After 4 weeks, answer:

- 1. Which drill felt routine? (evidence of skill building)
- 2. Which drill still felt uncomfortable every time? (priority for next cycle)
- 3. Has any real-world scenario type NOT appeared in drills? (add it to a custom set)

Adjust the next cycle based on gaps, not on what felt good to do.

Custom drill set D (yours to fill)

Add real messages, real scenarios, anonymized or fictional. The closer to your actual situation — the more useful the drill.

#	Message / scenario	Tag	Routing
1	__		
2	__		
3	__		
4	__		
5	__		

This set should grow over time. Hard items that keep appearing in your observer log become drill items here.

Phase — 11-reflection-evening-loop

Directory: `11-reflection-evening-loop/`

Source: `11-reflection-evening-loop/01-three-evening-review-questions.md`

Evening review — three questions, 90 seconds

What this is

At the end of the day, instead of letting your mind churn through the same loops, you ask yourself three specific questions. The whole thing takes 90 seconds. That limit is not a suggestion — it is the point. If you go over, you are not reviewing, you are ruminating. Start again shorter.

When to use this

Each evening before bed, or at the end of your work day. Takes 90 seconds total. Each answer is one sentence.

How to do it

Ask yourself these three questions out loud or in writing. One sentence each. Stop when you have answered all three.

Question 1: What fact changed today? Something that actually happened. Not how you feel about it — just the fact. “I received the document.” “The meeting was rescheduled.” “He did not respond.”

Question 2: What did I do today that moved me toward stability? Not what others thought of you. Not whether you were impressive. Something you did, however small, that was genuinely stabilising for you or your situation.

Question 3: Who was I trying to impress today — and can they actually give me what I was looking for? This is the honest one. Name the audience. Then honestly ask whether they are capable of giving you what you were seeking. Often the answer is no.

If you go over 90 seconds: Stop. Start again with shorter answers. Shorter is better than thorough.

Weekly check: Look at Question 3 only. Mark whether your honesty on that question went up, stayed flat, or slipped. No essay. One arrow.

Connects to

- `../03-observer-loop/02-after-talk-reset-and-review.md`
 - `../09-daily-mechanics/01-universal-micro-ritual.md`
-

Source: `11-reflection-evening-loop/02-evening-review-template.md`

Evening review template — 90 seconds, three questions

Run after dinner, not immediately after the hardest moment of the day. Distance is part of the tool.

The three questions

Answer each in one sentence. If you run over, restart shorter. Brevity is the gate — longer means you’re storytelling, not auditing.

Q1: What fact changed objectively today?

Not feeling. Not interpretation. What actually happened that is verifiable?

Example: “The court date was postponed to July.” / “I sent the document.” / “The conversation happened and lasted 20 minutes.”

Answer: ____

Q2: What did I do today that was oriented toward stability — not toward proving something to someone?

Acts count. Thoughts and intentions do not.

Example: “I slept before midnight.” / “I walked instead of responding to that message.” / “I stayed on topic during the call.”

Answer: ____

Q3: Which audience was I performing toward today — and can they actually supply the validation I was seeking?

Name the audience honestly. Then ask the hard question.

Example audience: “My lawyer.” “My ex-partner.” “Some imagined panel of judges.” “My own internal critic.”

Can they supply what I was seeking? Often: no. The partner cannot validate me. The lawyer evaluates procedure, not character. The panel doesn’t exist.

Audience: ____

Can they supply it: Yes / No / Partly

Weekly trend tracker

Once a week, look back at Q3 answers. Mark the pattern:

Week	Q3 direction	Trend
____	____	↑ more external / → stable / ↓ less external

No essay needed. One arrow per week.

Full daily log template

Date: _____
Morning digit: _____ (from morning protocol)
Evening digit: _____ (1-5 same scale)

Q1 – fact: _____
Q2 – stability: _____
Q3 – audience: _____ | Can supply: Y / N / Partly

One thing to carry forward tomorrow: _____

Warning signs in the answers

These patterns signal the review is being used for rumination, not audit:

- Q1 answer includes emotional language: “it was unfair that...”
- Q2 answer is about what you avoided feeling, not what you did
- Q3 answer names the same audience 5+ days in a row with no shift
- Review takes more than 5 minutes

If any of these appear — stop, reset the sequence, answer shorter.

Integration

Morning digit → compare to evening digit over 7 days → shows whether days tend to improve or worsen under current load.

Evening Q2 → feeds into [Observer daily log](#) — what was regulated, what slipped.

Source: 11-reflection-evening-loop/02-unblocking-paralysis-micro-forward-motion.md

When you are frozen — separating real threats from fear stories

What this is

When you are stuck, overwhelmed, or unable to move forward on something, there are two very different things that might be happening. The first is a learned fear — your mind is running a catastrophic story based on older experiences, not on what is actually in front of you right now. The second is a real material threat — something that actually needs action, possibly professional help.

These feel identical from the inside. Treating a learned fear story like an urgent real threat keeps you spinning in circles. Treating a real threat like just anxiety causes you to avoid getting actual help.

When to use this

- When you have been stuck on the same problem or thought for more than 30 minutes
- When a fear feels urgent but you cannot identify the actual next step
- When you are exhausted by your own internal arguments about a problem
- During any period where you feel blocked multiple days in a row

How to do it

Step 1 — List what is worrying you. Write down up to ten things that are causing anxiety right now. Do not filter or rank them yet.

Step 2 — Separate each one. Mark each item with either L (learned fear — a story your mind tells, based on older patterns, not a current material fact) or R (real threat — something that actually requires a concrete action or professional help).

Step 3 — Deal with each correctly. - R items: do not argue with yourself about them. Get actual help. A lawyer, a doctor, a professional, a trusted person. Solo internal debate does not resolve real threats. - L items: do not feed them with more analysis. Go to physical regulation first — movement, breathing, grounding. Then come back to thinking.

Step 4 — If you have been stuck on a task for more than 30 minutes: Set a timer for five minutes. Do only actual work on the task for those five minutes. When the timer ends, stop and log whether you worked or stopped. That is it. No longer sessions required.

Step 5 — During a blocked period (multiple days in a row): Pick one small forward step each day and do it. One thing. That is enough.

Example

You have been going around in circles about a legal situation for two hours. You label it: “Is this an L or an R?” The threat is real — it needs a lawyer, not more internal debate. You stop arguing with yourself. You write “call lawyer” as tomorrow’s one action and close the loop for tonight.

Connects to

- [../02-regulation-and-recovery/](#) — do physical regulation before returning to the thinking
 - [../09-daily-mechanics/01-universal-micro-ritual.md](#) — the daily one-action commitment
-

Phase — 12-active-life-design

Directory: `12-active-life-design/`

Source: `12-active-life-design/01-building-life-offensive-layer-overview.md`

Building your life — shifting from survival to active choices

What this is

After a long period of conflict, stress, or crisis, most of your energy goes into managing damage — staying stable, not making things worse, getting through the day. That is survival mode, and it is sometimes the only realistic option.

But at some point, conditions shift enough that you can start making deliberate choices about where to invest your energy, rather than just defending yourself. This is the shift from survival to active life building. It does not mean the hard things are over. It means you have enough stability to start choosing, not just reacting.

This phase covers five practical areas: who you spend energy on, whether relationships give back proportionally, widening your options before you feel cornered, making faster decisions on things that are reversible, and recognising when moral grievance loops are consuming your energy without producing progress.

When to use this

Use this when: - The daily fire-fighting has reduced enough that you have some capacity to think ahead - You notice your calendar is still entirely reactive even though the crisis has passed - You have been in survival mode for so long that it has become the default, even when it no longer needs to be

If life design still feels insulting — if you are still in the thick of it and reading this makes you angry — stop here. Stay with the regulation and recovery work until the baseline clears. This phase is not relevant until it feels reachable.

How to do it

One line each day: Write down today's stability bottleneck, and whether thinking about life design feels aspirational or insulting. If it feels insulting, park this work and return to regulation.

One outward action each week: Pick one thing that widens your options or deepens something healthy. Put it on the calendar. Examples: coffee with a trusted person, restoring a logistics channel you have been avoiding, politely reducing contact with someone who drains you. Calendar it as a real appointment, not as an aspiration.

Connects to

- `02-conflict-decision-sequence-flag-pointers.md` — so not every incoming challenge defaults to full engagement
 - `03-positive-life-bandwidth-social-identity-and-joy.md` — protecting the parts of life not defined by conflict
 - `../02-regulation-and-recovery/` — if this phase feels unreachable, stay here first
-

Source: `12-active-life-design/02-conflict-decision-sequence-flag-pointers.md`

Before engaging in conflict — a quick filter

What this is

When a conflict situation arises, most people respond on autopilot — either avoiding it entirely, or diving in harder than necessary. Neither is a decision. This is a short filter you run before engaging, so you are choosing how to respond rather than just reacting.

The filter has four questions and four possible responses.

When to use this

- Before you respond to any message or situation that feels charged
- Before entering a difficult conversation
- At any point mid-conversation when you notice you might be losing ground or draining energy

How to do it

Before engaging — ask four questions:

1. Does this actually matter? Would it affect anything real if you ignored it?
2. Is there a real risk if you do not engage?
3. Is there a specific goal you can actually reach by engaging?
4. What is the most proportionate response?

Then choose one mode:

- **Engage fully** — the issue matters, there is real risk, and you have a reachable goal.
- **Minimum only** — say the minimum required. Do not elaborate, do not explain yourself at length.
- **Create distance** — slow down the interaction. Delay, defer, reduce frequency.
- **Exit** — disengage entirely. Not every conflict deserves your time.

During a long conversation — periodic check: At any point where you notice you are working hard but nothing is moving, pause and ask: am I still making progress toward my goal, or am I just draining energy? If the answer is the latter, downgrade your mode.

Example

You receive a message that provokes you. Before responding: Does this actually matter? Is there real risk? Is there a reachable goal? If the answer to all three is no, the mode is minimum or exit. You write two sentences and stop.

Connects to

- [01-building-life-offensive-layer-overview.md](#)
- [../05-communication-under-pressure/](#) — for handling the conversation once you have chosen to engage

Source: [12-active-life-design/03-positive-life-bandwidth-social-identity-and-joy.md](#)

Protecting your life outside the conflict

What this is

When conflict goes on long enough, it starts to take over your whole identity. Every friendship, every hobby, every future plan starts to feel like it connects back to the conflict in some way. Without noticing, you stop being a full person and become someone whose entire life is defined by a fight.

This file is about deliberately carving out parts of your life that have nothing to do with the conflict. Not as a luxury, but as a practical requirement for staying functional.

When to use this

- When you realise you cannot remember the last time you did something just because you enjoyed it
- When your sense of who you are is entirely defined by the conflict or the process around it
- When friendships and hobbies have quietly disappeared over the past months

How to do it

Quarterly relational check: Look at who you have actually been in contact with versus who you say you value. Pick one person you have drifted from and make one small reconnection gesture — a message, a coffee, a call. Do not force it. One gesture is enough.

Weekly protected time for a hobby: Block ninety minutes per week for something that is not work and not conflict. Low skill is fine. A walk with a camera, a book, cooking something, a physical craft. The point is that it is protected time and it actually happens.

Three identity sentences: Write three sentences about who you are that contain no words related to the conflict, the process, or any of the people involved. Say them aloud occasionally. Example: “I am a good cook. I know a lot about mountains. I am reliable with people I care about.” Keep them simple and true.

One future marker on the calendar: Put one non-adversarial thing on the calendar at least 90 days from now. A trip deposit, a course, an event, a mundane upgrade you have been putting off. It does not need to be significant. It just needs to exist and to have nothing to do with the conflict.

Scheduled weekly joy: Put one enjoyable thing on the calendar each week. Music, a meal you like, something that reliably makes you feel like yourself. Calendar it as a real appointment. If it is only an aspiration it will not happen.

If everything shrinks during a spike: Temporarily reducing these things during an acute crisis is normal. Abandoning them for months without reassessment is not. If months pass and none of this is happening, talk to someone you trust or a therapist about it.

Connects to

- `01-building-life-offensive-layer-overview.md`
 - `02-conflict-decision-sequence-flag-pointers.md`
 - `../02-regulation-and-recovery/` — pair with recovery work so the schedule stays realistic
-

Phase — 13-professional-work-load

Directory: 13-professional-work-load/

Source: 13-professional-work-load/01-professional-relationship-under-pressure-overview.md

Staying professional when private stress and work overlap

What this is

When you are under serious private stress — legal proceedings, family conflict, major life disruption — it leaks into your work life whether you intend it to or not. The pressure to vent, to perform, to win small conversational battles at the office goes up. The cost of those small wins is usually higher than it looks.

This file is about staying professionally functional when everything else is heavy. The tools are simple: stay calm in meetings, keep written records, avoid sharing personal drama at work, and use official channels for anything that needs escalating.

When to use this

- When private stress is noticeably affecting how you show up at work
- Before any meeting where emotions are likely to run high
- When you notice you are sharing more personal information with colleagues than is wise
- After any meeting that went badly or felt volatile

How to do it

In meetings: Stay calm. If something provokes you, do not respond in the moment. Your goal is to be unremarkable — steady, factual, forgettable in the best sense.

Keep written records: After any important conversation or meeting, write five short factual bullet points within a few minutes of it ending: - What happened - What was decided - What was committed to - Who is doing what - The timeline

Do this before processing how you feel about it. The factual record needs to be written while it is fresh. The emotional processing can wait.

Do not share personal drama with colleagues: Not even with people you trust at work. The workplace is not the right container for it, and anything shared informally can travel in ways you did not intend.

Use official channels for escalation: If something needs to be raised formally, use HR, your manager, or whatever official process applies. Do not escalate through side conversations, group chats, or informal alliances.

Reply-all adrenaline: If you have a history of sending reactive broadcast messages when activated, watch that specifically. The impulse to CC everyone, reply-all, or escalate in writing when emotional is one of the most costly patterns in professional settings. Trend it down deliberately over a month.

Example

A meeting turns hostile and you leave feeling activated. Before you do anything else — before you call someone to vent, before you send a follow-up email — write five factual bullet points about what happened. Then wait. Process the emotion later and on a safer channel.

Connects to

- ../01-operational-stance/ — pacing and stance under pressure
 - ../07-audiences-channels-boundaries/ — choosing the right channel for the right message
-

Phase — 14-appendix-custody-expert-proceedings

Directory: `14-appendix-custody-expert-proceedings/`

Source: `14-appendix-custody-expert-proceedings/01-expert-session-topic-map-and-mini-brief.md`

Preparing for evaluator or expert sessions

This is not a substitute for legal counsel. Always align your preparation with your lawyer before any session.

What this is

When you have a session with an evaluator, expert, or similar professional in a custody or safeguarding process, what you say matters — but so does how you say it. Evaluators notice whether you are calm and clear, whether you keep the focus on your child, and whether you can describe conflict without attacking the other parent.

This file helps you prepare what to cover and how to rehearse it.

How to prepare

Five topic areas to prepare:

1. **Your personal background** — a brief, factual description of who you are. Keep it under 25 seconds. Lead with stable caregiving, not with achievements or grievances.
2. **Description of the conflict** — describe what happened without attacking the other party. Keep the child in the foreground. Evaluators notice when a parent cannot describe conflict without it becoming an attack.
3. **Your parenting picture** — your child's daily routines, their interests, your relationship with them, how you spend time together. This should be specific and concrete.
4. **How you handle stress** — be honest and practical. What do you do when things are hard? What support do you have?
5. **Logistics** — practical arrangements, schedules, how you handle transitions and communication.

For each topic: Mark your confidence as high, medium, or low. Any topic marked low gets one recorded aloud practice pass before the session.

How to rehearse

Practice aloud, not in your head. Reading notes silently does not prepare you for speaking under pressure. Say the answers out loud. Record yourself if possible and listen back.

Crisis or difficult questions: Practice answering hard questions in no more than two clear sentences. Stop after two sentences. Do not over-explain.

Dry-run standard: Keep rehearsing until you can do three consecutive self-reviews where your speed and volume stay steady throughout. That is when you are ready.

Connects to

- `../05-communication-under-pressure/` — staying steady when the questions are hard
 - `02-questions-cheatsheets-knjige-reading.md` — practice banks for specific question types
-

Practice banks for custody and evaluation questions

What this is

Preparation for custody-related evaluations only works if you practice answering questions out loud. Reading notes silently, highlighting, or reviewing cheat sheets in your head does not prepare you for the real thing. This file organises the four layers of practice you use at different times.

The four practice layers

Layer 1 — The long question bank (weekly practice) A broad set of questions covering all likely topics. Each week, pull seven questions you have not seen recently and answer each one aloud in 45 seconds or less. After each answer, name which communication technique you used — pause, short answer, neutral tone, redirect to facts. Archive audio only if a coach or lawyer would benefit from hearing it.

Check each answer against four things: Did you pause before answering? Did you stop at the right moment? Did you keep a steady tone without matching any hostility in the question? Did you avoid repeating any insult or accusation back?

Layer 2 — Short warm-up bank (when time is tight) A smaller set of five to ten questions for days when you have limited time before an appointment. Quick pass, aloud, to get your voice and pacing activated.

Layer 3 — Term and concept reference sheet (day-of review) A list of key terms and concepts you may encounter. On the day of a session, read through it once, slowly. Immediately after reading, answer two surprise questions aloud from memory without looking back at the sheet. The goal is to keep the knowledge available in your head — not to memorise scripts.

Layer 4 — Emergency orientation card (at the door) A single card you read in under one minute immediately before entering. Orientation only — who you are, what your goal is, what tone you are aiming for. No new information. No cramming. Just grounding.

Weekly practice routine

1. Pull seven unseen questions from the long bank.
2. Answer each one aloud in 45 seconds or less.
3. Note which technique you used after each answer.
4. Track total oral repetitions week by week. As appointment dates get closer, this number should go up, not down.

A note on reading books

General books on communication or psychology can be useful for context and perspective. They do not replace spoken practice. If you are reading more than you are practicing aloud, the ratio is wrong.

Connects to

- 01-expert-session-topic-map-and-mini-brief.md
 - ../05-communication-under-pressure/ — technique routing for specific question types
 - ../06-situation-literacy/ — reading what is actually happening in the room
 - ../04-cognitive-distortion-literacy/ — for when your inner narrative starts running ahead of the facts
-

Phase — 15-identity-and-narrative-reconstruction

Directory: 15-identity-and-narrative-reconstruction/

Source: 15-identity-and-narrative-reconstruction/01-inherited-narrative-audit.md

Inherited narrative audit — what is mine, what was installed

Not all beliefs you carry about yourself are yours. Some were installed — through repetition, pressure, or long-term dynamics in which someone else defined who you are. This audit separates them.

Why this is necessary

When someone tells you who you are often enough and loudly enough — you start to believe them. Especially if that person was close, if you were exhausted, or if you were in a position where defending yourself consumed all available energy.

The result: you carry a story about yourself that isn't yours. You act from it, make decisions from it, sometimes defend it even when it harms you.

The goal of this audit is not to convince you that you are perfect. The goal is to give you freedom through **distinction** — what is mine, what is not — so you can choose what you keep.

Part 1 — Belief inventory

Write your answers to these questions. You're writing for yourself, not for an audience. There are no correct answers.

What do I believe about myself in these areas:

As a parent: _____
As a partner: _____
As a person in conflict: _____
As someone who makes mistakes: _____
My worth: _____
My stability: _____
My capability: _____

Do not filter. Write what you actually believe — even if it embarrasses you.

Part 2 — Origin test

For each belief you wrote, ask these three questions:

Question A: Where does this belief come from?

- ☐ My own experience — I see this in my behaviour over time
- ☐ Someone else's assessment — someone told me this, repeatedly or forcefully
- ☐ Combination — partly mine, partly absorbed
- ☐ I don't know

Question B: When did I start believing this?

Before a specific person / situation: _____
During or after: _____

If you held this belief before — it's likely yours or older, not installed by that person. If it appeared during or after a specific dynamic — that is a signal.

Question C: Who benefits from me believing this?

Me (it makes me better, holds me accountable): _____
Someone else (it weakens my position, justifies their actions): _____

This is not a conspiracy theory. This is a practical question: does this belief work for you or against you?

Part 3 — Most commonly installed beliefs (recognise if any are yours)

These are beliefs frequently installed through prolonged conflictual dynamics or toxic relationships. Read the list. Mark those you recognise in yourself.

[] "I am too emotional / unstable."
[] "I can't trust my own read of situations."
[] "I'm always the one who ruins things."
[] "My needs are too much."
[] "The children would be better off without my influence."
[] "I'm not good enough as a parent / partner / person."
[] "Others see clearly – I'm the biased party."
[] "My anger / sadness / fear proves I'm in the wrong."
[] "When I'm happy, it's a brief pause – I'm fundamentally a bad person."
[] "I have to try twice as hard to prove I'm normal."

For each one marked: apply the test from Part 2.

Part 4 — Separation

For beliefs that are **installed** (not yours), write:

Belief: _____
What is actually true in this (if anything): _____
What is exaggerated, distorted, or untrue: _____
What would I say about this if I were rested, safe, and free of pressure? _____

That last answer — “what I would say without pressure” — is the starting point for your own narrative.

Part 5 — Operational rule

When you receive a message, comment, or legal document that activates one of those installed beliefs:

1. Recognise: “this is targeting an installed story about me”
2. Do not defend against the installed belief — defending it confirms it
3. Return to your own narrative (file 03 of this phase)
4. If a response is needed — respond from your story, not theirs

Integration

Run this audit once thoroughly, then revisit every few months or after an intense period of pressure.

The results feed into → [Building your own narrative](#)

Recognising an installed belief in real time → [Observer daily log](#) — add to Story channel: “this is their story / this is my story”

Mindfulness as an observational tool — a thought is not a fact

Mindfulness here is not meditation in the classical sense. It is training one specific skill: noticing a thought before it becomes your reality.

What this does

Between “someone says you are bad” and “I believe I am bad” there is a gap.

Mindfulness practice builds that gap. The wider the gap — the more space you have to choose what to do with that. The narrower it is — the more automatically you absorb someone else’s narrative as your own truth.

This connects directly to the [Observer loop](#) — but goes deeper: not just labelling in the moment, but training yourself to recognise a thought as an **event in the mind**, not a **description of reality**.

The core distinction

Automatic mode	Mindful mode
“I am a bad parent.”	“I’m having the thought that I’m a bad parent.”
“This is going to end badly.”	“I notice a thought that this will end badly.”
“I am not good enough.”	“This thought has shown up again.”

The shift is not denial. You are not saying “that isn’t true.” You are saying: “this is a thought — I can examine it rather than swallow it.”

Practice 1 — Thought as a cloud (5 minutes daily)

Intended for: morning or before a difficult interaction.

Steps:

1. Sit quietly. Close your eyes if you can.
2. Notice the first thought that appears. Don’t generate it — just wait.
3. When it arrives, label it internally: “*Here is a thought.*”
4. Visualise it as a cloud passing across the horizon. You don’t push it away — you don’t hold it either.
5. Wait for the next one. Repeat.

What you will notice: - Thoughts arrive uninvited - They don’t all carry equal weight - When you don’t press against them or defend from them, they pass faster

Log (optional):

Date: _____
Loudest thought today: _____
I noticed it: immediately / with a delay / not at all

Practice 2 — Body scan as an early signal (3 minutes)

Intended for: before, during, or after a difficult interaction.

An installed narrative arrives with a physical signal — before the thought becomes a sentence, the body already knows.

Steps:

1. Stop. Three slow breaths.
2. Scan from feet to head — where is there tension?

Jaw: relaxed / tight
Shoulders: relaxed / raised
Chest: open / constricted
Stomach: relaxed / tense
Hands: open / clenched

1. Which part of the body is most activated?
2. Ask: “What is running in my mind right now that is creating this?”

Why: Installed narratives have a characteristic physical signature. When you recognise it — you have 2–3 seconds before you respond automatically. That is enough.

Practice 3 — Separation sentence (real time)

Intended for: when you notice that someone’s word, message, or situation is activating you.

Internal sentence (never aloud):

“I am having the thought that [X]. This is a thought, not a fact. I can examine it.”

Examples: - “I am having the thought that I was unfair to the children. This is a thought, not a fact.” - “I am having the thought that I am not good enough. This is a thought, not a fact.” - “I am having the thought that everything will fall apart. This is a thought, not a fact.”

Important: You are not telling yourself you are perfect. You are telling yourself this deserves examination, not automatic acceptance.

After the sentence — apply the test from [Inherited narrative audit](#): is this mine or absorbed?

Practice 4 — Weekly mindfulness log (10 minutes weekly)

Week: _____

Most frequent thought about myself this week: _____

Origin (mine / absorbed / unknown): _____

How many times did I notice it BEFORE it pulled me: ____/____

Situation where the gap was largest (noticed, did not react automatically):

Situation where it pulled me without awareness:

What would help next week: _____

Integration into the existing system

Mindfulness practice does not run separately — it layers into what you already do:

Existing tool	Mindfulness layer
Observer daily log — Story channel	Add: “is this story mine or absorbed?”
Morning protocol — stress digit	Add Practice 2 (body scan) before writing the number
Message classification drill	Before classifying: Practice 3 — separation sentence
Evening review	Q1 answer: is this a fact, or a thought about a fact?

What this is not

- Not suppressing thoughts

- Not positive thinking
- Not ignoring problems
- Not a spiritual practice (unless you want it to be)

This is **training one precise skill**: noticing an automatic thought before it becomes your identity.

Source: 15-identity-and-narrative-reconstruction/03-own-narrative-construction.md

Building your own narrative — a story from evidence, not from hope

Your own story is not built from affirmations you don't believe. It is built slowly, from concrete evidence out of real experience, while the installed narrative gradually loses ground.

Why affirmations don't work (when someone has convinced you that you are bad)

If someone tells you “you're a great parent” and you deeply believe you're not — your mind rejects it. It is too far from the installed belief.

What works is something more modest and precise: an **evidence log** — a record of concrete moments that align with who you actually are, without exaggeration.

Not “I am a great parent.” But: “today I sat with my child for 20 minutes and was present. That happened.”

The accumulation of those records, over time, becomes the foundation of a new narrative — grounded in real experience, not in wishful thinking.

Part 1 — Definition: who you are by behaviour

A story about yourself cannot begin from feeling (“I feel like a good person”) or from someone else's approval (“they say I'm...”). It begins from **behaviour that is visible and repeatable**.

Fill this in:

Three things I do consistently, without an audience:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Three values I would recognise in my own behaviour – even in difficult periods:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

One thing I know to be true about myself, even when pressure pushes me to forget it:

These are starting points. They don't need to be grand — the more concrete they are, the more resistant they are to external pressure.

Part 2 — Evidence log (daily practice, 2 minutes)

Every day, one sentence. Concrete, not emotional.

Format:

“[Date] — [What you did / how you behaved] — this is consistent with [value].”

Examples:

"12.03.2026 — Waited for my child to finish their sentence before responding. Patience."

"14.03.2026 — Did not respond to a provocative message today. Chose not to engage. Self-control."

"17.03.2026 — Acknowledged a mistake to the children directly and without drama. Accountability."

Rules: - One entry — no more, no less - Only what actually happened - Do not write anything you are not certain is true - Do not skip days when things were hard — those days especially have something worth recording

Log format (weekly review):

Week: _____

Monday: _____

Tuesday: _____

Wednesday: _____

Thursday: _____

Friday: _____

Saturday: _____

Sunday: _____

Which value appeared most often this week: _____

Which value was harder to show: _____

Part 3 — Identity statement (not an affirmation — a claim from evidence)

After 2–3 weeks of the evidence log, write three sentences about yourself in first person.

Rules: - Each must be supported by at least one concrete example from the log - No superlatives ("I am the best") - No direct refutation of someone else's story ("I am not what they say") - Written about behaviour, not about feelings

Examples:

"I am someone who remains present for my children even when exhausted. I showed this on [concrete moment]."

"I make decisions from accountability, not from fear — even when that costs me in the short term. I showed this when [concrete moment]."

"I know the difference between a mistake and a character defect. I make mistakes, correct them when I can, and move on."

Write your three:

1. _____
Evidence: _____

2. _____
Evidence: _____

3. _____
Evidence: _____

These statements are your foundation when external pressure tries to push you back into the installed narrative.

Part 4 — Protecting the narrative under pressure

The installed narrative returns most easily during: - Physical exhaustion - Unexpected attack (written, verbal, or official) - Silence — when there is no external validation for an extended period - After a mistake

For each of these moments, prepare one anchor — a short sentence you return to.

When exhausted, my anchor is: _____

When under attack, my anchor is: _____

When validation is absent, my anchor is: _____

When I make a mistake, my anchor is: _____

An anchor is not false comfort. An anchor is a sentence grounded in evidence from the log — something you know to be true even when you don't feel that it is.

Part 5 — Separating from someone else's story in real time

When you notice that someone's words are activating an installed narrative (using the mindfulness practice from file 02):

1. **Pause** — do not respond immediately
2. **Name it**: "this is targeting an installed story about me"
3. **Anchor**: say your identity statement to yourself
4. **Classify the message**: I / P / H (from [Message classification drill](#))
5. **Respond from your narrative**, not from theirs

Example sequence:

You receive a message: "You were never a stable parent."

Pause. → "This is targeting the installed narrative." → Anchor: "I remain present for my children." → Classification: P (provocation) → Routing 6 (refuse premise) + Routing 2 (care-forward) → Respond with one factual sentence or do not respond.

How this develops over time

Weeks 1-2: Audit (file 01) — understand what is not yours
Weeks 3-4: Mindfulness (file 02) — practise the gap between thought and reaction
Weeks 5+: Evidence log + identity statements — build your own foundation
Month 2+: Anchors become automatic, installed narrative loses force

This is not a fast process. The installed narrative was built over years — your own takes months. What matters is regularity, not speed.

Integration

Evidence log entries → [Evening review Q2](#): "what did I do toward stability today" maps directly to the log.

Anchors → [Morning protocol](#): if stress digit is 4-5, read one anchor before the first difficult interaction.

Identity statements → when the observer loop catches you in a Story channel that is not yours — return to these statements.

Phase — 16-cbt-practical-tools

Directory: 16-cbt-practical-tools/

Source: 16-cbt-practical-tools/01-activated-state-protocol.md

Activated state protocol — when something hits you

What this is and why it works

When something activates you — a message, a comment, a situation, a conversation — your brain shifts into defensive mode. In that state you do not think clearly, you do not assess accurately, and everything that comes out of you in the next few minutes is likely coming from fear or anger, not from genuine reasoning.

The problem is not that you get activated. The problem is that in an activated state you make decisions, send messages, and form conclusions about yourself and the situation that are not accurate — and that stay with you long after the moment has passed.

CBT (cognitive behavioural therapy) has a straightforward mechanism for this: **between the event and the reaction, insert a structured step that slows down and examines the thought before it becomes a belief or an action.** You are not eliminating the emotion — you are examining it.

This is not for every day. This is for moments when you notice you are activated and a thought is circling or pulling at you.

When to use this protocol

Use it when you recognise at least one of the following: - You received a message or comment that hit you and you have a strong impulse to respond immediately - One thought about yourself or the situation keeps returning and you cannot release it - You feel strong shame, anger, fear, or emptiness connected to a specific situation - Something that happened an hour, a day, or a week ago is still “working” in you

Protocol — three steps

Step 1 — Immediately (0–2 minutes)

Put down the phone or close the laptop. Do not respond to anything.

Set a timer for **20 minutes**.

During this time: do not re-read the message, do not talk about the situation, do not analyse. Just wait. This is not weakness — it is technique. The brain in acute activation cannot examine objectively. 20 minutes changes the chemistry enough for the thought to become accessible.

If it is urgent and you must do something: write one neutral sentence that contains no position. “I see your message, I’ll respond shortly.” That is all.

Step 2 — After 20 minutes (10–15 minutes)

Open this file. Answer the questions in order, in writing — not in your head. Writing slows down and concretises a thought in a way that thinking alone cannot.

Question 1: What exactly happened?

Write only the event — no interpretation, no “because”, no “which means”. One or two sentences.

Example: “I received a message saying I was not present for my child last week.”

Not this: “I received a false accusation designed to paint me as a bad parent.” — this is already interpretation, not event.

Your answer: __

Question 2: What was my first automatic thought?

Write it literally, exactly as it came — even if it seems irrational or shameful. It is there. Better to see it than to push it down.

Example: “Maybe they’re right. Maybe I really am not enough.”

Example: “They’re doing this deliberately to destroy me in court.”

Example: “I cannot take this anymore.”

Your automatic thought: ____

Question 3: How strong is the emotion? (0–10)

Name the emotion as precisely as you can and give it a number.

“I feel bad” is not enough — bad is too broad. The mind does not know what to do with it.

Emotions common in these situations: **fear** (something bad will happen), **anger** (injustice, attack), **shame** (maybe they’re right about me), **sadness** (loss, helplessness), **anxiety** (uncertainty, what will happen next).

Example: “Shame — 8/10. Some anger — 5/10.”

Your emotion and number: ____

Question 4: Does this thought speak about the event, or about who I am?

This is the key question. There are two types of automatic thoughts:

Type A — thought about the situation: “This message is untrue.” / “This is a pressure tactic.” → May be accurate, may not be — but it speaks about the event, not about you.

Type B — thought about identity: “I am not enough.” / “I always ruin things.” / “I am a bad parent.” → This is an installed narrative that the event has activated. It is not the same as assessing the event.

If your automatic thought is Type B — it deserves specific attention in the following questions.

Your answer (Type A / Type B / both): ____

Question 5: What is the evidence FOR this thought? What is the evidence AGAINST?

This is the heart of the CBT approach. You are not asking “is this true?” — you are asking “what is the actual evidence?”

Fill both columns. If you skip one side — the exercise does not work.

Evidence FOR this thought	Evidence AGAINST this thought
—	—
—	—
—	—

Example for the thought “I am not enough as a parent”:

FOR	AGAINST
I didn’t call my child for two days last week	Every week I have a routine with my child that has worked for years
I sometimes raise my voice	I attended every school event this year
We haven’t talked about the problems they’re having at school	My child comes to me when something is difficult

Important: evidence must be concrete and verifiable — not feelings (“I feel like a bad parent”) but actual events and behaviours.

Question 6: What would a person who respects me say, having seen the same evidence?

Not someone who flatters you. Not someone who attacks you. Someone with genuine goodwill who would be honest.

What would they say about your automatic thought?

Example: “They would say that a few lapses don’t define the whole picture. That the effort is visible. That the perfect parent is a myth.”

Your answer: ____

Question 7: What is the balanced thought — the one that includes both sides?

Not optimistic. Not pessimistic. Accurate, as much as you can be.

Example: “I have lapses as a parent, and I also have things I do well and consistently. One message does not describe the whole.”

Your balanced thought: ____

Question 8: How strong is the emotion now? (0–10)

Same scale as before — what is the number now?

Emotion and number: ____

If it dropped by at least 2–3 points: the protocol worked. The emotion has not disappeared — it has shifted into something you can function from.

If it has not dropped: that is normal. Sometimes a second pass is needed, or the thought is more complex and warrants work with a therapist. It is not failure — it is information.

Step 3 — Decision about response

Now, from this state, decide:

- Does this need a response? (Not always necessary)
 - If yes — what is one sentence grounded in facts, not in emotion?
 - If no — what do I do instead? (Use [Reset protocol](#) or [Observer log](#))
-

Three worked examples

Example 1 — Message with accusation

Situation: Received a message: “The child tells me that when you’re with them you’re always on your phone and not paying attention.”

Automatic thought: “Maybe I really am like that. Maybe I don’t see how much I neglect my child.”

Emotion before: Shame 7/10, anxiety 6/10.

Type of thought: Type B — speaks about identity.

Evidence FOR	Evidence AGAINST
I sometimes check my phone when we’re together	Every weekend we do an activity my child chooses
I once cancelled an outing because of work	My child tells me what’s happening at school every day
—	When my child asks for attention, I put my phone away

What someone who respects me would say: “Every parent checks their phone sometimes. The question is overall presence, not perfection. The overall picture is not neglect.”

Balanced thought: “I have moments when I am not fully present, and I also have many moments when I am. This message describes one aspect, not the whole.”

Emotion after: Shame 3/10, anxiety 3/10.

Decision: Will not respond to the message today. Next week I will consciously keep my phone in my pocket for the entire time with my child.

Example 2 — Thought circling before sleep

Situation: No external trigger — but the thought “I’m not good enough” is circling before sleep.

Automatic thought: “Everyone else is functioning better. I am barely surviving.”

Emotion before: Sadness 8/10, listlessness 6/10.

Type of thought: Type B — identity + comparison.

Evidence FOR	Evidence AGAINST
Last week I didn't finish an important task	This month I managed to take my child to every scheduled appointment
I feel exhausted most days	I have not missed a single work deadline in the past three months
—	I have been through a period that would exhaust anyone

What someone who respects me would say: “You are functioning under pressure that most people could not sustain. ‘Barely surviving’ in these circumstances is actually surviving — which is not nothing.”

Balanced thought: “I am exhausted and it is affecting my functioning. I am still functioning. This is not a state that describes who I am — it describes the current pressure.”

Emotion after: Sadness 4/10, listlessness 3/10.

Decision: No action tonight. Tomorrow morning — one item from the morning protocol.

Example 3 — After a difficult formal meeting

Situation: A meeting with a lawyer / mediator / institution where you were under pressure and did not say everything you intended.

Automatic thought: “I showed myself badly again. I’m not capable of defending myself when it matters.”

Emotion before: Anger (at self) 7/10, frustration 8/10.

Type of thought: Type B — capability + identity.

Evidence FOR	Evidence AGAINST
I didn't say X that I had planned	I stayed calm throughout the entire meeting
I accepted one premise I shouldn't have	I asked one important question that changed the direction
I forgot a key document	I arrived prepared with material

What someone who respects me would say: “You entered a difficult meeting under pressure. Not everything went perfectly and you didn’t sink either. One poor showing does not define capability.”

Balanced thought: “This meeting did not go as I wanted. I have things to improve. That is concrete information for next time — not evidence about who I am.”

Emotion after: Anger 3/10, frustration 4/10.

Decision: Write notes on what I would do differently — for preparation before the next meeting. Not rumination.

Most common mistakes when using this

Mistake 1: Using the protocol in the hot moment It does not work. The brain is not accessible. Wait at least 20 minutes.

Mistake 2: Skipping the evidence AGAINST column “There is nothing AGAINST” — almost never true. If you cannot find anything, that is a signal you are still too activated, not that there is no evidence.

Mistake 3: Writing feelings instead of evidence “I feel like a bad parent” is not evidence. “I missed the agreed appointment on Tuesday” is evidence.

Mistake 4: A balanced thought that is just optimistic “Actually I’m great and everything is fine” — that is not a balanced thought, that is a defence. A balanced thought includes what did not go well.

Source: 16-cbt-practical-tools/02-recurring-thought-protocol.md

Recurring thought protocol — when the same thought will not stop

What this is and why it differs from the activated state protocol

There are two kinds of difficult thoughts:

Kind 1 — Reactive thought: something happened, you are not present, your brain reacts. For that there is the [Activated state protocol](#).

Kind 2 — Recurring thought: no concrete trigger, but the same thought keeps returning. Before sleep. In the shower. While driving. In the silence between situations. No new event — but the thought is always there, slowly draining energy.

Recurring thoughts are more dangerous than reactive ones because they have no clear trigger to signal that you should address them. They work quietly, in the background, and gradually shape how you see yourself and your situation — almost without you noticing.

This protocol is for that second kind.

How to recognise a recurring thought

Ask yourself: - Does this thought come every day, or multiple times a week, without a specific cause? - Do you already sense how the thought begins the moment you have a little silence? - Do you try to shake it off or stay busy to avoid feeling it? - Has this thought existed for months or years?

Two or more yes answers — this is a recurring thought and it warrants this protocol.

Protocol — five steps

Step 1 — Name the thought precisely (5 minutes)

Recurring thoughts are often vague — “something is wrong with me”, “this will not end well”, “I am not good enough”. That vagueness gives them power, because you cannot examine something that has not been precisely formulated.

Write the thought as a concrete statement. Do not paraphrase — write it literally, as it arrives.

Vague (not this): “I have a feeling that something is off with me.”

Precise (this): “I believe I am fundamentally a bad person and that others have seen this.”

Vague: “I worry about the future.”

Precise: “I believe the court will rule against me and I will lose contact with my child.”

Vague: “I feel worthless.”

Precise: “I believe I am not worthy of love and that everyone around me would be better off without me.”

Your precise thought: ____

Step 2 — Classify the thought (3 minutes)

Once you have the precise formulation, ask yourself:

Is this thought a prediction, an assessment, or an identity statement?

Type	Description	Example
Prediction	About what will happen in the future	“The court will rule against me.”
Assessment	About what something means or its value	“What I did is unacceptable.”
Identity statement	About who I am as a person	“I am a bad parent / bad person / a failure.”

Why classification matters: - Predictions can be tested against reality — what do the actual facts say about the future? - Assessments can be nuanced — one behaviour ≠ total worth - Identity statements are the most vulnerable to installed narratives — they almost always call for an audit from [file 01 of phase 15](#)

Type of your thought: ____

Step 3 — Examine the thought (10–15 minutes)

The questions differ depending on the type of thought.

If it is a PREDICTION:

Q1: What is this prediction based on? List concrete pieces of evidence that support it — actual events only, not feelings.

Q2: What evidence speaks against it or reduces its probability?

Q3: How many times in the past have you predicted a similar outcome and been right? How many times wrong?

Our minds are biased prediction machines — we systematically overestimate negative outcomes. This question asks you to check your own prediction track record.

Q4: If the prediction comes true — what would you do? Have you survived difficult things before?

This is not optimism. This is a realistic assessment of capacity.

Q5: What is the more realistic version of this prediction, based on all the evidence?

If it is an ASSESSMENT:

Q1: What specifically am I assessing as unacceptable / bad / a failure? Write the specific event or behaviour — not the general picture.

Q2: Does this single behaviour or event describe the whole?

The mind under distress makes generalisations — one event becomes “always”, “never”, “everyone”, “nothing”. Write what would be a more accurate formulation.

Instead of: “I wasn’t present for my child.” More accurate: “On that Tuesday I was not as present as I wanted to be.”

Q3: What standard would you apply to another person in the same situation?

We are almost always harder on ourselves than on others. Write how you would assess another person in an identical situation with identical circumstances.

Q4: What would be a fair assessment — one that includes context and the whole picture?

If it is an IDENTITY STATEMENT:

This is the most complex type. Before examining the thought here — run the [Inherited narrative audit](#) to establish whether this statement is yours or installed.

If you have already done the audit, or if you are uncertain, continue:

Q1: Where does this statement come from? When did it first appear?

Q2: What concrete evidence from your actual behaviour supports this statement?

Literal examples. Not “I feel bad” — but “I did X.”

Q3: What concrete evidence from your actual behaviour contradicts or complicates it?

Literal examples. This is the hardest question. Do not skip it.

Q4: If this statement were entirely true — how do you explain the evidence from Q3?

A mind holding an identity statement must ignore contradictions. Here you bring them into awareness.

Q5: What would be a more accurate identity statement — one grounded in all the evidence from both Q2 and Q3?

Example: Instead of “I am a bad parent” → “I am a parent who has lapses and who tries and who is consistently present. No parent is either perfect or simply bad.”

Step 4 — Define the new thought and anchor it (5 minutes)

Write one sentence that represents a more accurate version of the original recurring thought — grounded in the evidence you have just reviewed.

This is not an affirmation. It is not “everything is fine.” It is a thought you have earned through examination.

Example of original thought: “I am fundamentally a bad person.” New thought: “I have flaws and I have qualities. This thought comes from a period of pressure, not from an objective assessment.”

Example of original thought: “The court will rule against me.” New thought: “I do not know what the outcome will be. What I can control is preparation and conduct.”

Your new thought: ____

Anchor it: Write it on paper and put it somewhere visible, or save it in your phone as a reminder. The recurring thought will not stop immediately — but each time it arrives, you can attach the new thought to it rather than swallowing it whole.

Step 5 — Track over time

A recurring thought that has existed for years will not disappear after one pass of this protocol. But it weakens with each pass.

Log:

Date: _____
Original thought: _____
Type (prediction/assessment/identity): _____
New thought: _____
Strength before (0-10): _____
Strength after (0-10): _____
Note: _____

Once a week: look at entries for the same thought type. Is the number trending downward over time? If not — the thought is more complex and is worth exploring with a CBT-trained therapist.

Four worked examples

Example 1 — Identity statement (parenting)

Original thought: “I am not enough as a parent and my child would be better off if I were less present in their life.”

Type: Identity statement — installed through prolonged conflict.

Q1 (origin): This thought intensified during the separation. I did not have it before that.

Q2 (evidence FOR): - I sometimes raise my voice - I was physically absent some weeks due to work

Q3 (evidence AGAINST): - Every week I have a routine with my child that has functioned for years - My child comes to me when they have a problem - I have attended every important event - My child seeks my company

Q4 (explaining the contradiction): A mind holding this thought must minimise everything in Q3 as “not enough” — but that standard would not be applied to any parent anywhere.

Q5 (more accurate statement): “I am a parent who has lapses and who is consistently present and to whom my child matters. This thought is not my assessment — it was installed through a conflict situation.”

Strength before: 8/10. **After:** 4/10.

Example 2 — Prediction (outcome of proceedings)

Original thought: “I will lose the case and lose contact with my child.”

Type: Prediction.

Q1 (evidence FOR): - The other side has more resources - One decision has already gone against me

Q2 (evidence AGAINST): - I have documentation and witnesses - The previous negative decision was procedural, not on the merits - Courts generally do not exclude a parent without strong grounds

Q3 (prediction track record): Over the past year I predicted five “certain” bad outcomes. Two partially came true, three did not.

Q4 (if it comes true): I would be devastated. And — there are legal appeal pathways. I am not without options. I have survived worse than I thought I could.

Q5 (realistic prediction): “I do not know what the outcome will be. I have reason to believe I am not in an insignificant position. Preparation is what I can control.”

Strength before: 9/10. **After:** 5/10.

Example 3 — Assessment (behaviour in conflict)

Original thought: “What I said during that argument is unacceptable and proves I am not capable of normal relationships.”

Type: Assessment.

Q1 (concrete event): In one argument three months ago I said something harsh and unfair.

Q2 (the generalisation): One argument → “incapable of normal relationships” is a leap that does not follow logically.

Q3 (standard for another person): If a friend told me they had once said something harsh in an argument, I would not conclude they were “incapable of normal relationships.” I would say they were under pressure and this was an isolated event.

Q4 (fairer assessment): “I said something harsh in one argument under significant pressure. That is behaviour not to repeat — it is not a characterisation of my entire capacity for relationships.”

Strength before: 7/10. **After:** 3/10.

Example 4 — Combined (worth and future)

Original thought: “Nobody truly loves me and I will end up alone.”

Type: Identity statement + prediction. Break it into parts.

Part A — “nobody truly loves me”: Evidence FOR: Some relationships have cooled or ended during this difficult period. Evidence AGAINST: I have friends who have been there. My child wants my presence. A colleague reached out out of concern. More accurate thought: “Some relationships have cooled. I also have relationships where care is shown. ‘Nobody’ is not accurate.”

Part B — “I will end up alone”: This is a prediction based on current state, not on an inevitable future. More accurate thought: “I currently feel isolated. That is the state of this period, not a permanent outcome.”

Combined new thought: “I am going through a period of isolation that is a consequence of circumstances. That is not a permanent state nor proof of my worth.”

Strength before: 9/10. **After:** 5/10.

Integration with the rest of the path

- When a recurring thought points toward identity → [Inherited narrative audit](#)
 - When you notice the thought arriving → [Mindfulness — separation sentence](#)
 - When activation remains after the protocol → [Reset protocol](#) Tier 1
 - New thought from Step 4 → goes into [Evidence log](#) if grounded in concrete evidence
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